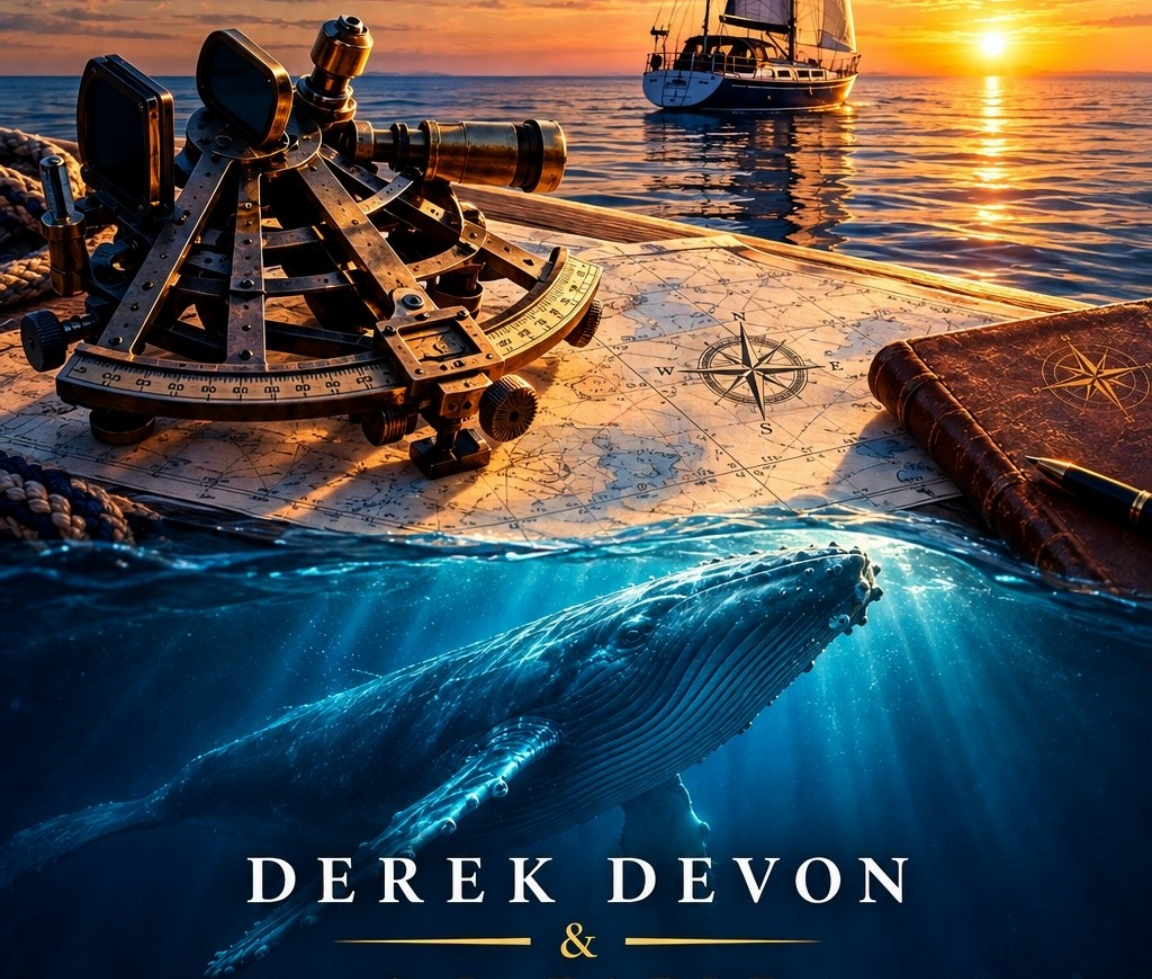


A SAILOR'S FINAL SOLO SAIL

*One man.
One boat.
An ocean of
unknowns.*



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A Sailor's Final Solo Sail

Derek Devon & A.I. Fable



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Chapter One: Searching

Nick Charters woke because nothing woke him.

For thirty-one days the boat had woken him. A sheet easing on a winch, the autopilot's small complaint when a wave shoved the stern, the change in the note of water passing the hull that meant the wind had gone light or come on hard. A man alone on the ocean does not sleep so much as wait with his eyes closed, and every part of him that could hear had learned what to listen for. He would be up and in the cockpit before he knew why.

What woke him this time was silence, and it took him a while to understand that. He lay in the quarter berth with his eyes open and his hand already on the lee cloth, and he listened, and there was nothing. No water on the hull. No creak from the rig. Not the tick of the autopilot ram. Not the small electric hum from the panel that he

had stopped hearing in the first week and only noticed now because it was gone.

He looked at his wrist. The watch was a Garmin his daughter had given him, the kind that took its time from the satellites. The face said SEARCHING.

He had never once seen it say that at sea.

He got up. His knees told him about the last thirty-one days, and he told them he had heard it before. The cabin was grey with the light that comes before the sun. He went up the companionway steps and stood in the cockpit in his shorts and looked around him at the world.

The sea was flat. He had seen calms before. Every sailor who crosses the Atlantic from west to east meets the Azores High somewhere between Bermuda and Faial and motors through it cursing, because the high sits over the middle of the ocean like a fat man on a bench and nothing can

move him. He had planned for it. He had carried extra fuel in jerrycans lashed to the rail, and he had burned most of it, and the high had let him go and given him three days of a fine northwesterly that had carried him to where he was now. He had expected the wind to hold to the islands.

This was not a calm. A calm has swell in it. The ocean breathes under a calm, long and slow, the memory of wind from a thousand miles away.

This sea did not breathe. It lay there. It was the colour of slate where the sky was still dark and the colour of pewter where the sky was lightening, and it was so still that when he leaned over the rail he saw his own face looking up at him, and the face was not moving either.

The mainsail hung from the mast in folds. He had left it up overnight with a reef in it because the wind had been steady and he wanted to be ready. Now it hung like laundry. The yankee was furled on its stay and the staysail was bagged on the

inner one. The boom sat dead centre and did not swing.

"All right," he said. His voice went out over the water and did not come back.

He looked at the sky. It was clear, high, and empty. Not a cloud. Not the high thin haze that comes ahead of weather. He turned in a slow circle and looked at the horizon all the way round, and there was nothing on it, which was normal, and then he looked up again and realised what else was missing. He had crossed under the great circle route from the northeast of America to the whole of Europe for a month. Every day there had been contrails. Little silver knives, high up, two or three at a time. He had watched them the way a man in the desert watches birds.

There were no contrails.

He went below. The chartplotter at the nav station was on. The screen showed the chart, the

Atlantic between Bermuda and the Azores, blue and empty, and in the middle of it where the boat should have been there was nothing. In the corner the small icon flashed: NO FIX. He looked at it for some time. He tapped the screen. He turned the unit off and on. It came back and thought about it and said NO FIX.

The AIS showed no targets, which meant nothing, because there had been no targets for days. He switched on the sat phone. It powered up, found itself, and then began to search for a network, and he watched the little bar chase itself for a full minute before he understood that it was going to do that forever.

He picked up the VHF handset and pressed the button.

"Any vessel, any vessel, this is sailing vessel Halcyon. Radio check, over."

He waited. He had not expected an answer. There was no one within twenty miles to answer, there never was out here, but he had wanted to hear the little rush of static when he let go of the button, the sound that meant the set was live and listening. It was there. The set was fine. It was the world that was quiet.

He sat down at the nav station and he made himself think.

The first thing an engineer does, his old boss used to say, is separate what he knows from what he is afraid of. Nick had been an engineer for thirty-four years, most of them at the paper mill in Bucksport until it closed, and after that for himself, fixing other people's boats along the Maine coast. He knew what he knew.

He knew the boat was fine. He could feel it. Halcyon was a 42-foot cutter built in Rhode Island in 1984 of fibreglass so thick you could not

put a screw through the hull without a pilot hole and a prayer. He had owned her nineteen years. He had rebuilt her twice. He knew the sound of every pump and the smell of every locker, and nothing was wrong with her.

He knew the electrical system was fine. The panel lights were on. The batteries read 13.7 volts. The solar controller was already showing a trickle from the first light on the panels.

He knew the instruments were working. The depth sounder said the sea was deeper than it could measure, which was true. The wind instrument at the masthead said zero, which was true. The compass said what compasses say. The plotter was working. It was only that there was nothing for it to hear.

That was what he knew. What he was afraid of was another thing.

He reached for the logbook. It was a proper book, cloth-bound, the pages ruled, and he wrote in it in pencil because pencil does not run. He had written in it every day for a month. He turned back a page to see what he had written last, before he slept.

Day 31 out of Bermuda. Time 2140. Wind NW 12-15, steady. Speed 6.2. Course 072. Reefed main, full yankee. Glass 1029 (Barometer), rising. Sky clear. Aurora to the north, low, and then not low. Whole northern sky. Red, then green, then red. Never seen the like at this latitude. Watched it an hour. Lucky man. N.C.

He read it twice. He had gone to bed happy.

He knew about the aurora. Anyone who reads knows about it, and a marine engineer knows more than most, because the story of the sun's tantrums is also the story of everything with a wire in it. In 1859 a British astronomer named

Carrington saw a white flash on the face of the sun, and eighteen hours later the sky over the whole earth lit up red as far south as Cuba, and the telegraph wires threw sparks and set the paper on the operators' desks alight, and the aurora was bright enough at midnight to read a newspaper by in Boston. That was the story.

There had been others since, smaller. The one in 1989 had put Quebec in the dark for nine hours. And every few years someone wrote an article saying that a Carrington-class storm was a matter of when and not if, and the grid would go, and the satellites would go, and the article would be read by a few hundred people and forgotten.

He had watched it from the cockpit with a cup of tea and thought it was beautiful.

He looked at the watch on his wrist. SEARCHING.

He turned to a fresh page.

Day 32. 0605. No wind. No sea. Glass 1034. Sky clear, no cloud, no contrails. No GPS fix. No sat network. VHF live, no traffic. All ship's systems normal. Position by DR approx 33°20'N 42°30'W. Aurora last night – see above. N.C.

He looked at what he had written. It was true and it was small, and he knew that whatever this was, it was not small.

He went up on deck and dropped the main. There was no reason to leave it up. He flaked it on the boom the way he always did, and tied it, and the work of his hands calmed him a little, as it always did. Then he sat in the cockpit with his back against the coaming and watched the sun come up out of a sea like a sheet of tin, and he thought about his daughter.

Jo would be asleep. It was an hour after midnight in Portland. She would be asleep, and the boys, and Dan, in the house on Munjoy Hill with the

good view of the harbour, and the phone would be on the table by her bed with the ringer on, because on Sundays her father called from the middle of the ocean and she did not want to miss it. Today was Thursday. He had three days to work out how to call her.

The sun came up. It came up as it always did, and he watched it, and it warmed his face, and he thought, that is the thing that did this. That, right there. And it went on rising, indifferent, over the stillest sea he had ever seen.

Chapter Two: Inventory

He gave himself the day to be systematic, because the alternative was to sit in the cockpit and think, and he had seen where that led in men who were alone too long.

He started with the boat, because the boat was the thing he could touch.

He opened the engine box and looked at the Perkins. It was a 4-108, fifty horsepower on a good day, and it had been built in 1983 by men who did not trust electricity and had put as little of it in the engine as they could manage. There was a starter motor and there was an alternator and there was a solenoid to stop the fuel, and that was all. Everything else was iron, steel, and diesel. He had rebuilt it himself the winter Mara was sick, in the shed, with the radio on, because he had needed something to do with his hands that had an answer at the end of it. He checked the oil.

He checked the raw-water strainer. He turned the key and it caught on the second turn and ran, and the sound of it in the still morning was enormous. He let it run five minutes and shut it down and the silence came back like water into a hole.

Then he did the sum he had been avoiding.

The tank held two hundred litres. The gauge said a quarter, and the gauge was optimistic; he dipped it with the stick and got fifty-five. The jerrycans on the rail were empty. He had burned them in the high, day after day of it, motoring at five knots into a sea like oil, and he had done it gladly because on the other side of the high was the wind, and the wind had come, and he had thought the worst of the crossing was behind him. Fifty-five litres. The Perkins burned two and a half an hour at cruising revs. Twenty-two hours. At five and a half knots, a hundred and twenty miles.

He did not yet know where he was, but he knew it was not a hundred and twenty miles from anywhere.

He went through the electrical system next. This was where he had spent the money, and he had spent it well. Eight hundred watts of solar on the arch and the coachroof. Six hundred amp-hours of lithium under the saloon settee, in a case he had built himself. A battery monitor that told him what went in and what came out to a tenth of an amp. All of it was fine. The sun was on the panels now and the monitor said they were putting in thirty-one amps. By noon it would be fifty. He could run everything on the boat forever, as long as the sun shone, and there was no sign that the sun would ever stop shining.

He worked down the list. Watermaker: it drew eleven amps and made twenty-eight litres an hour and it was fine. Fridge: fine. Lights, pumps, autopilot, all of it fine, all of it useless or nearly.

The radar he left for last. He turned it on and let it warm up and watched the sweep go round, and it showed him twenty-four miles of nothing in every direction, which was information, of a kind.

He wrote it all down.

The pattern was so plain that he was ashamed to have taken two hours to see it. Everything that lived on the boat worked. Everything that lived in the sky was gone. The GPS receiver was healthy; it simply could not hear its satellites. The sat phone was healthy; it could not find its network. The plotter's chart was there, drawn from memory, but the little boat on it had no way to know where to draw itself. He was not blind. He was in a world that had gone deaf.

He thought about what that meant and made himself stop, because the thinking would come later whether he wanted it or not, and now he needed the position.

He got out the sextant.

It was a Tamaya, Japanese, forty years old, in a wooden box with a brass hook. He had bought it from a widow in Rockland who had wanted it to go to someone who would use it, and he had used it, twice a year, on the way to Bermuda and back, to keep his hand in. Every sailor who crosses oceans says he can navigate by the stars if the electronics fail, and most of them are lying, and he had made it a point of pride not to be one of those. He had shot the sun every day of this crossing and worked the sight and compared it to the plotter and been pleased when they agreed to within two miles.

The last sight he had worked was yesterday noon. He had a good position from that, and a good log reading since, and a good course, and he knew how far he had come. He plotted the dead reckoning. It put him at 33° (*degrees*) 22' (*minutes*) North, 42°28' West. He drew a small circle around

it and wrote the time beside it. Then he waited for noon.

While he waited he did the food. He had provisioned in Bermuda for sixty days because a solo sailor provisions for the crossing he fears, not the one he expects. Thirty-two days gone. He went through the lockers with the notebook. Rice, pasta, flour. Tinned beans, tinned fish, tinned tomatoes, tinned everything, powdered whole milk. The foil packets of freeze-dried meals he had bought for storms and hated. Onions and potatoes in the net, going soft. Eggs, the last dozen, turned every day. Coffee, thank God, plenty. He counted and he wrote and he made himself be honest about portions, and what he came to was forty days if he ate as he had been eating, and sixty if he did not.

The water was easy. The watermaker would run as long as the sun shone.

At 1140 he went on deck with the sextant and shot the sun as it climbed. He shot it every two minutes until it stopped climbing and hung there, and then began to fall, and he had his meridian passage. He went below and worked it. Latitude from a noon sight is the easy one: the sun's declination out of the almanac, the paper one, and the zenith distance off the sextant, and a minute's arithmetic, and he came out with 33°19' North. The longitude he got from the time of the passage against the ship's clock, a quartz clock on the bulkhead that had never in its life been told the time by a satellite, and he got 42°26' West. The dead reckoning had been three miles out. He was pleased, and then not pleased, because the pleasure did not matter.

He put the position on the paper chart. Then he took the dividers and walked them out to the land.

Faial, in the Azores: seven hundred and eighty miles, a little north of east.

Bermuda, behind him: nine hundred and ninety.

Flores, the westernmost of the islands, was a little closer than Faial, but there was nothing at Flores. Faial had Horta, and Horta had a harbour, and fuel, and a chandlery, and a café where the yachts wrote their names on the harbour wall, and he had been looking forward to it for a month.

Seven hundred and eighty miles. A hundred and twenty on the engine. Six hundred and sixty with no wind.

He put down the dividers.

Day 32, cont. Noon position by sun 33°19'N 42°26'W. Faial 780 nm, brg (bearing) 078. Fuel 55 L. Water full, maker OK. Food 40-60 days. All ship's systems normal. Sky: no satellites answering. Nothing on radar 24 nm. Wind nil. Glass 1034, steady. N.C.

He made lunch and ate it in the cockpit, in the shade of the bimini, because the sun was fierce now and the air had no movement in it at all. Sweat ran down his back and did not dry. He looked at the water. It was flat enough that a fly could have walked on it. He had never in his life seen the ocean without a ripple. Even in the flattest calm there is the cat's-paw, the dark patch, the ruffle from a puff so slight you feel it on your ear before you see it. There was nothing. The surface was a skin.

He thought about the aurora. He thought about the telegraph paper catching fire in 1859, and the transformers in Quebec in 1989, and all the articles he had read and half-forgotten. If it had been that, if it had been the big one, then the satellites would be the first to go. They were up there naked. A storm like that would fry them or knock them off their orbits or simply blind them. Then the grid. The long wires. The induced

currents would run through the continental grids like water through a pipe and the big transformers, the ones that take a year to build, would cook in their oil. And then, because everything ran on the grid and the satellites, everything would stop.

Not the boat. The boat did not run on the grid. The boat was a short piece of wire in a big sea, and the storm had passed over her the way a wave passes over a cork.

He did not know if that was what had happened. He knew it fit.

What did not fit was the sea.

A solar storm did not stop the wind. He was sure of that. It touched the top of the atmosphere, a hundred miles up, where there was hardly any air at all. It did not reach down and put its hand on the ocean. The calm was something else. The Azores High, swollen and stuck; he had seen that

before, though never like this. He had read somewhere that the sun's moods could reach the weather, that a change high up in the stratosphere could work its way down over weeks and lock the jet stream in a shape and hold it there. He did not know if that was science or the kind of thing that gets said. It did not much matter. He was under it, whatever it was.

In the afternoon he rigged the awning over the boom and lay in the cockpit under it and did what he had told himself he would not do, which was think about Jo.

She would not know. That was the first thing. If the grid had gone, and the phones, and the satellites, she would not know that anything had happened to him, because she would not know anything about anything. She would be in a dark house in Portland with two boys and a husband and a stove that ran on gas, thank God, and she would be thinking about water and food and

whether the neighbours had a generator, and somewhere at the back of it she would think, Dad, and know there was nothing she could do. She was practical. Mara had been practical and Jo was more so. She would manage.

He did not let himself think further than that, because further than that was the boys, and the boys were seven and four.

When the sun got low he took the sextant up again and shot it as it went down, for the practice, and then he shot Polaris when it came out, and worked that, and it agreed with noon. He wrote it in the log. The stars came out the way they had come out every night of his life, and he lay in the cockpit and looked at them and they were exactly as they had always been, and that was the strangest thing of all.

*Day 32. 2100. Evening star sight agrees with noon.
Wind nil. Sea flat. Glass 1035. No lights, no
aircraft, no ships. Very quiet. N.C.*

Chapter Three: Noon

The days took a shape, and the shape was the sun.

He woke before it, because he always had. He made coffee on the gimballed stove that did not need to gimbal. He checked the boat, though there was nothing to check; the same lines lay in the same coils, the same dew stood on the same deck. He wrote the morning entry. When he found himself thinking laziness, he would find a turnbuckle or two to polish. Then he waited for noon, because noon was the only thing that told him anything.

The second day the sun came up at 33°19' North, 42°25' West. He had drifted one mile west.

He looked at the figure for a long time. In an ocean, a boat with no way on her should drift ten miles, twenty, thirty. The current here ran east, weakly, part of the great slow wheel of water that

turned around the whole North Atlantic. In his experience it would carry a stopped boat a dozen miles between one noon and the next.

He checked the sight. He shot it again the next day, and the next, and the boat had moved two miles in three days, none of it east.

He sat with the chart and thought about that.

The wind drove the surface of the sea. Everyone knew the tides and the deep currents, but the skin of the ocean went where the wind pushed it, and when the wind had been pushing it for a week or a month it kept going after the wind stopped, the way a heavy cart kept rolling.

That was what a calm felt like from a boat: the wind gone but the sea still moving, the swell still coming through from somewhere, the current still setting.

Here the cart had stopped.

There was no swell because there had been no wind anywhere near enough to make one. The calm was not a hole in the weather but a lid on the whole ocean. The surface current had died because it had nothing to feed it.

He was sitting in the middle of the great wheel at the one moment in his life when the wheel had stopped turning.

He wrote that down, and then under it:

Or I am wrong, and the sun is wrong, and the clock is wrong, and I am drifting to Africa.

He had learned a long time ago that a man alone had to argue with himself in writing, because there was no one else to do it.

On the fifth day he saw the spot.

He had been shooting the sun every day for a month and had never looked at it. You did not look at the sun through a sextant. You brought it

down to the horizon through the shades, and what you saw was a disc of dim orange sitting on the sea.

That morning the air was so clear that he had the shades stacked. The sun came down into his eye as a flat copper coin, and on the coin there was a flaw.

He took the sextant down and looked at it, as if the instrument had done something.

Then he put it back up.

It was there. A little below the middle of the disc and to the right, a dark mark, not round, more like a thumbprint.

It was not on the mirror; he moved the sextant and the mark moved with the sun. It was not in his eye. He closed the other eye and looked with it.

There it was.

On the sun.

He knew what it was, in the way a man knows what a lump is before the doctor tells him.

Sunspots were common. There were nearly always some. But you did not see them with the naked eye through a sextant shade, not ordinarily, not unless they were enormous.

The one Carrington had seen in 1859 had been enormous. A great black ragged thing, a hole in the sun you could have dropped the earth through several times.

He shot the sun for its altitude, because he was a navigator before he was anything else, worked the sight, wrote the position, and then went back up and looked at the spot again.

Day 36. Noon 33°18'N 42°23'W. Drift since Day 32: 3 nm, mostly S. Wind nil. Sea flat. Glass 1036. Sun: large spot visible through full shades, lower right of

disc, size perhaps one-thirtieth of the diameter.

Never seen one before. N.C.

He understood that the spot was rotating.

The sun turned on its axis once in about four weeks, and everything on its face went round with it. A spot in the middle today would be at the edge in a week and gone behind for two weeks after that.

He had read that somewhere, years ago, and it had meant nothing to him.

It meant something now.

If the spot had thrown the storm that put out the world's lights, and it had done it when it was facing the earth, then it was going to turn away, and it was going to turn back, and he could watch it do it.

He was probably the only man alive who would.

The thought did not frighten him yet. It was too big. It sat in him like a stone in a boot.

The days went by. He kept the log and he kept the boat and he kept himself.

He had a routine for that too, learned the hard way on his first solo crossing, when he had let himself go and come into Bermuda with a beard full of salt and a look in his eye that had made the customs officer step back.

He shaved every morning, in a mug of fresh water, and put on a clean shirt. He washed once a week in a bucket. He read. He had a shelf of books, thirty of them, and he had been saving some.

He read *Two Years Before the Mast* again because Dana had sat becalmed off the Horn for weeks and had not complained about it much.

He did not read the ones about people going mad.

There was one book he did not open. Mara had tucked it into his kit before he left, between the charts, with a note that said he'd find it about a week out. *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*, that year's favorite of hers. He'd found it on the third day, read the note, and laughed, because Mara had said a book like that needed stillness to read properly, and out here he'd have nothing but. He put it on the shelf to save for a calm.

He had his calm now. Some evenings he took the book down and held it and did not open it, and put it back, and that was as far as he could go.

The heat was the thing. Without the wind there was nothing to take it away. By ten the deck was too hot to stand on barefoot, and by noon the cabin was an oven. He lived in the cockpit under the awning with a wet towel around his neck and the hatches open to a breeze that did not come. He rigged up a small 12v fan mounted near his

head that he would turn every now and then not for the moving air but for the sound of the motor.

He swam in the afternoons. He rigged a line over the side with a loop in it and went in, hanging there in water so clear he could see the keel from twenty feet away, blue going down to black.

The first time he did it he had a bad moment, hanging there with two miles of nothing under his feet and the boat sitting above him like a roof, and the thought came to him, unbidden, that he probably made excellent shark bait out here. It was not an unreasonable thought, and he did not pretend otherwise.

He made himself stay in anyway.

After that it was all right.

On the ninth day the spot was at the edge of the sun, a smudge on the rim. On the tenth it was gone.

He felt it go.

He knew it made no difference, that the sun was the sun and did what it did whether he watched or not. But he had been watching, and now there was nothing to watch.

The sky was clean and blue and empty. There were no contrails in it, and there was no wind.

That night he did the sum on the spot.

Twenty-seven days for the sun to turn once. The spot had been right of the middle on Day 31, when the sky went red, if it had turned as far in five days as he thought it had.

It had gone off the edge on Day 41.

It would come back on the other edge on about Day 55, and be in the middle again, facing him, on about Day 61.

He wrote those numbers in the back of the log and shut the book.

Day 41. Noon 33°16'N 42°22'W. Spot gone off W limb. Wind nil. Glass 1036. Ten days becalmed. Food 50 days at present rate. Read. Swam. Fine. N.C.

Fine was a word he used in the log the way Mara had used it on the telephone to her sister, and he knew it.

He started, in the evenings, to write the other thing.

It was not in the log. It was in a separate notebook, a cheap one from the pharmacy in St. George's, and he wrote in it after supper when the cabin was cool enough to sit in.

He addressed it to Jo.

He told himself it was so there would be a record, and that was true. But it was also true that on the evenings when he wrote to her he slept, and on the evenings he did not, he lay in the quarter

berth and listened to the nothing until two in the morning.

He told her about the aurora. He told her he had thought it was beautiful. He told her what he thought had happened, as plainly as he could, and what he did not know, and what he was going to do about it, which was wait for the wind, because the wind always came.

He told her he was fine and then crossed it out and told her he was well, which was different.

He told her about the spot on the sun. He told her to keep the boys out of the sun. He did not know why; it just came to him and he wrote it down.

He told her about the paper mill and the winter he had rebuilt the Perkins in the shed and how her mother had come out with soup at four o'clock every day and stood in the doorway and not said anything and gone back in.

He had not told her that before.

There had not been a reason.

He did not tell her he was afraid. He thought she could probably work that out.

On the fourteenth day there was still no wind, and the glass had not moved by so much as a millibar.

He decided he had waited long enough.

Chapter Four: Halcyon

He gave the engine a third of what he had.

It was not a decision he liked, and he made it the way he had made decisions at the mill when the machine was down and the men were standing around and every hour cost more than his salary: quickly, with what he knew, and without looking back.

Eighteen litres. Seven hours at cruising revs.
Forty miles, a little less.

Forty miles east, because east was where the islands were and where the wind ought to be, if there was any wind anywhere.

The reasoning was thin and he knew it. A calm the size of an ocean did not have an edge forty miles away.

But the alternative was to sit, and he had sat for two weeks, and something in him that had

nothing to do with reason had started to say that the sitting was the danger.

A boat that does not move is not a boat.

It is a raft with opinions.

He started the Perkins at first light on the fifteenth day. He let her warm up, put her in gear, and felt the shove of the propeller in the water, the first thing that had pushed him anywhere in fourteen days.

Halcyon put her shoulder down and went.

It was a strange thing to motor over that sea. The bow wave went out from her and lay on the water and did not fade. When he looked back, he could see the wake running straight to the horizon like a road, two lines ruled on the flat.

The boat was the only thing that had disturbed the surface, and the surface would remember it for an hour.

He steered by the compass. The autopilot could have done it, but he wanted the wheel in his hands.

He went east for six hours and fifty minutes and shut down.

Nothing had changed.

He had known it would not and he had done it anyway. Now there were thirty-seven litres in the tank and the sea was flat here as it had been there.

He stood in the cockpit in the silence after the engine and looked around and could have been in the same place.

There was no landmark. There never is.

But he felt the difference in his body, the way you feel it when you have walked out of a room and the room is behind you.

Day 46. Motored 0600-1250, course 078, 37 nm by log. Noon 33°24'N 41°38'W. Fuel 37 L. Wind nil. Sea flat. Glass 1036. Nothing. N.C.

He anchored.

That is, he could not anchor; the sea was three miles deep. He did the thing he did instead, which was to let the boat lie and take the noon sight and wait and take another the next day and see what the water was doing.

In three days it did two miles.

He had bought forty miles with a third of his fuel and the sea had not so much as blinked.

He did not use the engine again.

The name of the boat had come with her. He had thought about changing it, because there was a superstition about that and he was not superstitious, but he had a healthy regard for people who were.

In the end he had kept it because he liked it.

Halcyon.

He had looked it up. It was a bird, a kingfisher, in a Greek story. The gods had turned a grieving woman into it, and every winter for a week the sea went flat so she could nest on the water.

Those were the halcyon days, the days when nothing moved.

Mara had laughed at that.

"You've bought a boat named after a calm," she said. "That's a hell of a thing for a sailor."

He had said the calm was only a week.

She had said, "We'll see."

He thought about that a good deal, on the days after the engine.

He had a bad stretch then.

He had been expecting it and it came anyway, on about the twentieth day, the way weather comes when it has been forecast.

He woke and could not get up.

There was no reason to get up. There would be no wind and there would be no fix. The sun would come up and cross the sky and go down, and he would take the noon sight and write a number and the number would be the same number.

He lay in the quarter berth and looked at the underside of the cockpit sole and thought about what it would be like to simply not do it.

Not take the sight.

Not write the log.

Not shave.

He got up because Mara would have got him up.

She would have stood in the companionway with her arms folded and not said anything, which was worse than anything she could have said.

He shaved. He made coffee. He touched the spine of Mara's favorite book as he passed it. He shot the sun.

It was 33°26' North, 41°35' West.

He wrote it down.

Day 51. Noon as above. Twenty days becalmed.

Wind nil. Glass 1036, has not moved since Day 33. I have never known a barometer to do that. Halcyon fine. Not much else to say. N.C.

He went through the boat that afternoon, stem to stern, the way he had before every crossing. He found nothing wrong and fixed it anyway.

He replaced the impeller in the raw-water pump, greased the winches, and went up the mast on the ascenders.

He sat at the masthead in the terrible heat and looked down at the boat lying on her reflection like a toy on a mirror.

He looked out and saw nothing to the edge of the world.

Or nearly nothing — low on the water to the south, a paleness, there and then not, gone before he could bring the glasses up. Whales, he thought. Or a reflection playing with his mind. He watched a while longer. It did not come back.

Then he came down.

The swimming became something else after that.

He had been going in at four to keep the fear at bay, twenty strokes out and twenty back. One afternoon it occurred to him that a man who did nothing but wait for wind would meet that wind unfit to sail her. He worked out the boat's length close enough and started swimming it properly, bow to stern and back, counting laps the way he'd

once counted them for something else and could no longer remember why. Ten laps, then fifteen. His shoulders complained for a week and then stopped.

He still floated on his back when the laps were done, and looked at the masthead, and for a while did not think. From the water Halcyon was a lovely thing, her mast going up into a sky that had never been so blue, her hull going down into a sea that had never been so clear, the two halves meeting at a line so sharp he could have cut himself on it. But that came after the work now, not instead of it.

It was the twenty-second day.

Day 53.

He had been becalmed three weeks.

Chapter Five: The Giants

In the morning the thing he had seen from the crow'snest — the paleness he'd told himself was a trick of his eyes — was still there. It was not a trick. And it was closer.

He watched from the cockpit with his coffee. The three big ones lay on the surface a half-mile off, logging, which is what whalers called it when a whale lies still at the top of the water like a log and breathes. The small one was not still. It came up and went down, came up and went down, and each time the tail came up he saw the thing on it, and now, with the sun higher and the water like glass, he saw what the thing was.

It was net. A great tangle of it, green and orange, wrapped around the tail stock where the body narrowed before the flukes, and trailing behind for what looked like forty feet, and in the trailing part there were floats, the hard orange kind, and

something else that might have been a length of pot line with the pot still on it. Ghost gear. Every sailor knows it. The nets the trawlers lose and the pot lines the lobstermen lose, and it all drifts, and it goes on fishing forever with no one to haul it, and it takes what it takes. Turtles. Seals. Whales.

The small whale was dragging a fishing net across the Atlantic. Every time it lifted its tail to dive it lifted the net too, and the drag of it was what made it swim wrong, the hitch, the short blow. He watched it for an hour and understood that it was tiring. The big ones were feeding, if there was anything to feed on, and the small one was trying to keep up and could not, and they were waiting for it, and it was not going to get better.

He knew what he was going to do about the time he understood that, and he spent the rest of the morning telling himself why he should not.

It was a wild animal the size of a bus. Bigger. Sixty feet if it was a foot, forty tons, and it was frightened and hurt and it had a tail that could lift a car. People who did this for a living, and there were people who did, did it from a rigid inflatable with an outboard, in teams, with poles and hooked knives and cameras and a protocol, and they still got killed sometimes. The whale did not know he was trying to help. It knew there was a thing near it, and things near it had been bad for it lately.

He was one man in a fibreglass boat in the middle of an ocean where no one would come. If he was hurt, he was dead. There was no argument about that. If the tail took him in the water he would go under and not come up, and if it took the dinghy he would be in the water with a broken dinghy and a broken arm and a frightened whale, and Halcyon would be sitting there four hundred yards away, and nobody would ever know what

had happened to Nick Charters, because there was nobody left who could know anything.

He went through all of it and it made no difference. He had known it would not.

He got out the dinghy.

It was a rigid inflatable, ten feet, with a small electric outboard that he had bought because it was quiet and did not stink and Jo and Mara thought it was a good idea. He pumped up the tubes and hoisted it over the side with the spinnaker halyard and got the outboard on it and put in a battery. He thought about what he needed. A knife. He had a dive knife, a good one, but a dive knife was for cutting a line you could get your hand on, and he was not going to get his hand on this. He needed reach. He went below and found the boathook, which was eight feet of aluminium with a hook on the end, and he took

the hook off and looked at the bare end and thought.

It took him two hours in the cockpit with a hacksaw and a file and a roll of tape. He took the blade off the bread knife, which was serrated and long and the best steel he had, and he made a slot in the end of the boathook and set the blade in it and drove two pins through and taped it, and when he was done he had a thing that was neither a knife nor a spear but would cut a rope at eight feet. He made a second one from a fillet knife and a broom handle. He put on his old deck shoes with the good grip and his oldest swimming shorts and a long-sleeved shirt for the sun, and he put the dive knife on his belt, and he filled a bottle with water, and he put a mask and snorkel in the dinghy because he did not want to and knew he might need them.

He wrote in the log before he went, because that was the rule. If you were going to do a stupid

thing you wrote it down first so that whoever found the book would at least know what you had been trying to do.

Day 54. 1120. Juvenile blue entangled in net at tail stock, trailing 40 ft of net and floats. Going to try to cut it free from the dinghy. Two cutting poles. If this book ends here that is why. Jo, I am sorry. N.C.

He looked at the last three words and left them.

He took the dinghy across the water at a walking pace. The electric motor made a sound like a fridge. The three big whales did not move; they lay there, and as he came near them he saw the size of them properly for the first time, from the water, and his mouth went dry. One of them was longer than a tennis court. It had a blowhole he could have put his head into, and when it breathed, a hundred yards off, the sound of it came across the water and went into his chest.

The small one was beyond them. It was on the surface and it was not moving much, and he understood that it was resting, or had given up, and he did not know which.

He came up on it from behind and to the side, slowly, and stopped the motor fifty feet away and let the dinghy drift, and looked.

The net was wrapped four or five times around the tail stock. It had cut in. He could see it from here, the deep grooves where the rope had worked into the skin and the skin had grown around it and gone white and ragged. The animal had been dragging this for weeks. Months, maybe. Behind the wrap the net spread out on the surface, a raft of green mesh and orange floats and a black pot line with, yes, a wire pot at the end of it, hanging down in the clear water like a bird cage.

The whale's eye was on the side of its head, low down, and it was looking at him.

He did not know what to do with that. He had expected to feel something, and he felt a great deal, but none of it was useful. It was an eye. It was the size of a grapefruit and it was dark and wet and it was looking at him with an expression he could not read, because it was not a face, and he had no idea what it was thinking, or if it was thinking. He said, "Easy," out loud, in the voice he had used on Jo's horse, and felt like a fool.

He started on the trailing part.

That was the plan, and it was not much of a plan, but it was what the people who did this did. You did not go for the wrap first. You went for the drag, the forty feet of net and floats hanging off behind, because that was what was killing the animal and because you could get at it without going near the tail. He motored in slowly until he

was beside the raft of net and cut the motor and reached down with the boathook blade and got it under the mesh and pulled.

The net was old and the mesh was rotten in places and the blade went through it easily. He cut, and pulled, and cut, and the whale lay still. He got the pot line, the black rope, and sawed at it; it was better rope and it took a minute, and he felt the dinghy move as the whale shifted, and stopped, and the whale stopped, and he went on. The line parted and the pot went down. He watched it go, turning slowly in the blue, getting smaller, and gone. He cut the floats away one by one. Each time the whale lay still. He started to understand that it knew. He had no evidence of that and he was not a sentimental man and he knew it anyway.

In an hour he had the trailing net down to a few feet. What was left was the wrap itself, round the tail stock, and the wrap was the thing.

He sat in the dinghy twenty feet off the tail and looked at it and drank some water.

The tail was as wide as a garage door. It lay just under the surface, flat, the flukes spread, and the wrap sat above it on the narrow part, and he could see now that there were five turns, and that one of them was deep in, deeper than the rest, and had a knot in it. He would not get it from the dinghy. He knew that as he sat there. He could reach it with the pole, but he could not see what he was cutting, not from above, not with the light on the water, and if he cut wrong he would cut skin, and the whale would move, and if the whale moved with the tail he would be in the air.

He put on the mask.

I am going in the water, he thought, and then he thought, *no, I am not, that is insane*, and then he was over the side.

The water was warm on top and cold underneath and clear as air. He hung there with the mask on and looked, and the whale was there, all of it, the whole grey-blue length of it going away from him into the blue like a wall, like a building lying down, and it was so big that he could not see it as an animal, only as a place. The tail was in front of him. Above the tail the wrap. He could see it now, every turn of it, the rope gone into the flesh and the flesh gone white, and the knot, and he could see what he needed to cut and in what order.

He swam to it. He did not think about the tail. He kept the dinghy painter in one hand, held loose in the palm so that it would run if it had to, and the dive knife in the other, and he came up to the tail stock as slowly as he had ever moved in his life and put his free hand on the whale.

It was like putting his hand on a wet road. Firm and smooth and cold, and alive; he could feel it,

the enormous slow life under his palm, and the animal did not move.

He cut the outer turn. The rope was hard and sodden and the knife was sharp and it went. He cut the next. He was breathing through the snorkel and his breath was loud in his ears and the whale was beside him like the side of a ship, and he cut the third turn, and that one was in the flesh, and he had to get the blade between the rope and the skin, and he did it with his fingers, feeling for the gap, and there was blood in the water, a little, thin and dark, and the whale did not move.

The fourth turn had the knot. He worked at it. He got the blade in under one strand and sawed, and the strand went, and the knot loosened, and he got his fingers in and pulled, and it came, and the last turn, the fifth, fell away on its own and hung there in the water and sank.

He let go of the whale and kicked backwards and the tail came up.

It came up slowly. It rose out of the water in front of him like a wall going up, streaming, wider than he could see with the mask on, and it hung there against the sky, and then it went down, not hard, and the wash of it pushed him back ten feet and filled his snorkel with water and he came up spluttering with the painter still in his hand, and the whale was gone.

He hung there in the water and shook.

Then he heard it blow, a long way off, and he turned and saw it, two hundred yards, going up and down in the water the way the big ones did, the long easy roll, up and blow and down, and the tail came up clean when it dived and there was nothing on it.

He got back into the dinghy, which was the next challenge. It took him three tries. He sat in the

bottom of it with the water running off him and the two makeshift poles beside him and the mask around his neck, and he put his face in his hands, and he stayed like that for some time, and he could not have said whether his face was wet with the sea or with something else, and he did not try to work it out.

Day 54. 1640. Cut the net off the juvenile. All of it. Went in the water for the last of it. Do not tell your mother. Old habit, that. It swam off clean and is feeding with the others. I am all right. My hands are shaking and I cannot make them stop. N.C.

Chapter Six: Deep Water

They stayed.

He had not expected that and he did not know what to make of it, and he was careful, in the log and in his head, not to make more of it than there was. The whales had been in that square mile of water before he was; they had come there because they had been going north along the great slow road that blue whales travel in the spring, from the warm water where they bred to the cold water where they fed, and the road had stopped under them the way it had stopped under him. They were not staying for him. They were staying because there was nowhere to go.

But they were there, every morning, when he came up with his coffee. The three big ones logging on the surface a half-mile off, and the small one among them now, rolling and blowing with the others, keeping up. Some days they

moved a mile or two, feeding, and he would lose them, and in the afternoon they would be back. Once the small one came within a hundred feet of Halcyon and lay alongside her, and he stood at the rail and looked down at it and it looked up at him, and neither of them did anything, and after a while it blew, and the spray came over the rail and he tasted it, and it went down.

He wrote that in the notebook for Jo and not in the log. The log was for what was.

Day 57. Noon 33°27'N 41°31'W. Wind nil. Glass 1036. Whales still here, four, all feeding. Juvenile swimming normally, wound looks clean from the surface. Food 44 days. Fuel 37 L. N.C.

The food was the thing now. He had been eating well, because eating well was part of the routine that kept a man sane, and the routine had cost him. Forty-four days. He was not going to sit here forty-four days and then die politely, and he was

not going to reach the islands on thirty-seven litres of diesel, and so the food was the problem to solve first, and he solved it the way he had solved the problem of the net, which was to look at what he had and see what could be made to do something it was not made for.

He had a fishing rod. He had a great deal of fishing gear, in fact, because he had told himself in Bermuda that he would fish the whole way across and had not once put a line in the water, being always too busy or too tired or too happy sailing. He had trolling lures, the bright ones, that you dragged behind a boat doing six knots. They were useless. Nothing would take a lure that was not moving.

But he had something else. Two winters ago a man in Camden had died and his widow had asked Nick to help clear the workshop, and among the things Nick had taken because nobody else wanted them was an electric reel. A big one,

the kind the sword fishermen used off Georges Bank to fish the bottom in a thousand feet of water. Deep dropping, they called it. You put a pound of lead and a string of baited hooks on braided line and let it go down until it stopped, and if there was anything on the bottom that ate, it ate, and you pressed the button and the motor brought it up. He had thought it was a foolish thing to own. He had put it in the cockpit locker and forgotten it.

He got it out. The motor ran on twelve volts. He wired it to the boat's system and it worked, and he sat looking at it with something that was nearly happiness.

The problem was the depth. The chart said he was in three thousand fathoms. Eighteen thousand feet. Nothing lived on the bottom there that he wanted to eat, and no reel in the world had that much line. But the ocean is not a swimming pool; it has layers, and he knew from

the sword fishermen that the layers had things in them. At six hundred feet, eight hundred, a thousand, there was a whole country of fish that never saw the surface. Big-eyed silver things with sharp teeth. Some of them were good. In the Azores they caught them on handlines off the banks and sold them in the market.

He baited the hooks with the last of a tin of sardines and sent the rig down.

The line went off the reel in a whisper. He watched the counter. Three hundred feet. Five. Eight. He stopped it at nine hundred and let it hang there, and sat in the cockpit with the rod in a holder and his hand on the line, feeling for what nine hundred feet of braid might tell him.

For an hour it told him nothing. Then it jumped.

He let it work for a minute and then pressed the button, and the motor whined and the counter ran back, and it took four minutes to bring up

nine hundred feet, and at the end of it there were three fish on the string. He did not know two of them. They were the colour of tarnished silver with eyes like saucers and mouths full of needles, and they were a foot long, and they came up dead from the change in pressure. The third was a thing like a small cod. He cleaned them on the side deck and cooked the cod-thing in the pan with oil and salt and ate it in the cockpit at sunset, and it was good, and he sat there afterwards with the plate on his knee and felt something loosen in his chest that had been tight for three weeks.

Day 58. Deep drop reel works. 3 fish from 900 ft on sardine. Ate one. Good. Food problem is not solved but it has changed shape. Whales here. Wind nil. N.C.

He fished every day after that. He used some of the fish as new bait. Some days the line came up empty and some days there were five on it, and

he learned the hours and the baits and the depths, the way he learned everything, by writing it down. He salted what he did not eat, and dried it on the boom in the merciless sun, and the drying went fast. The food in the lockers stopped going down.

The other problem was the distance, and that one took him longer.

Seven hundred and forty miles, now, to Faial. The engine could do a hundred of them, no more. The wind could do all of them in five days if there had been any wind, and there was not, and he had stopped believing there would be. Three weeks. A barometer that had not moved in a month. He did not know what had happened to the weather and he had stopped expecting to know. He needed a way to move the boat that was not diesel and was not wind, and there was only one thing on Halcyon that could do that, and it was hanging off the back of the dinghy.

The electric outboard. Three horsepower, they called it, though that was the marketing; what it was in truth was a thousand watts, about, at full throttle, and it ran on a battery the size of a briefcase that plugged into the top of it. He had two batteries. He had bought the second one for the trip so that he could go ashore in an anchorage and back without worrying. Each one ran the motor for an hour flat out, or three hours at half, or most of a day at the sort of crawl that moved a dinghy at the speed of a walking man.

A dinghy was not a twelve-ton cutter. But a twelve-ton cutter on a sea with no wind and no wave and no current was not doing anything that fought back. He thought about the physics of it. At two knots the drag on a hull like Halcyon's was small, a fraction of what it was at six. The motor might do it. Not fast, but the motor might do it.

He spent a day building a bracket. There was a stern bracket already on the transom for a small

petrol outboard he no longer owned, and he took it off and looked at it and rebuilt it lower and stronger from a piece of teak and some stainless plate he had aboard for repairs, so that the electric motor would sit with its propeller two feet under the surface at the centreline, behind the rudder, where the water was undisturbed. He mounted the motor. He plugged in a battery. He put it in gear at a quarter throttle and went forward and stood at the mast and watched the water.

Halcyon moved.

She did not move fast. But the water began to go past her, and after a minute there was a wake, faint, straight, and the log on the instrument panel, which had read nothing for twenty-six days, read 0.8 knots, and then 1.2, and then, when he went back and pushed the throttle to half, 2.1.

He shut it off and stood in the cockpit with his hands on his hips and laughed out loud, the first time he had laughed in a month, and the sound of it went over the water to where the whales were, and one of them blew.

The sums took the evening. At half throttle the motor drew four hundred watts and made two knots. A battery would give him three hours. Two batteries, six hours, twelve miles. Then the batteries were flat and had to be charged, and the boat's solar could charge them, but the solar had to charge the boat as well, the fridge and the watermaker and the reel, and it put in about five kilowatt-hours on a good day, and every day was a good day now, and if he was careful and gave the outboard batteries the lion's share he could charge both of them fully every day and run the motor six hours every day and make twelve miles.

Twelve miles a day. Seven hundred and forty miles. Sixty-two days.

He sat looking at that number.

Then he thought about the house bank. Six hundred amp-hours of lithium under the settee, most of it doing nothing now that he was not running the autopilot or the plotter or the lights at night. If he could run the outboard off the house bank as well as its own batteries, he could run it all day. He looked at the outboard's plug and the voltage stamped on the battery and thought about it, and the voltage was wrong; the outboard wanted more than twelve. But he had a converter aboard, a step-up, that he had installed years ago for a piece of gear he no longer had, and he found it in the bottom of the electrical locker, and it was the right voltage, or near enough, and it was rated for the current, or near enough.

It took him two days to make it work and it nearly did not. He blew a fuse and then another and then found that the outboard did not like the

converter and would run for ten minutes and quit, and he took the converter apart and found a capacitor that was swollen and had no replacement and made one from two smaller ones in parallel, and put it back together, and the outboard ran for an hour, and then two, and he stopped it because he wanted to see the battery monitor and not because he had to.

On the house bank at half throttle he could run twelve hours a day and charge the rest. Two knots, twelve hours, twenty-four miles. Then the two small batteries on top, six more hours, another twelve. Thirty-six miles a day, on a good day, and there were no other kinds.

Twenty days to Faial.

He had food for forty-four and the fish.

Day 60. Electric outboard on transom bracket, running off house bank via converter. 2.0 kts at 400 W. Est. 30-36 nm/day. Faial 740 nm. Twenty-

one days. Departing tomorrow at first light.

Whales here. I do not know what they will do. N.C.

He did not sleep that night, and not because of
the sums.

Chapter Seven: Two Knots

He left at first light on the sixty-first day, and the whales came with him.

He had told himself they would not. He had said so in the log and he had meant it.

They were wild animals with somewhere to be, and a boat crawling east at the speed of a man walking was nothing to them.

When he looked back after an hour and saw the four blows go up behind him, a half-mile astern, he told himself it was chance.

When he looked back four hours later and they were still there, he stopped telling himself anything except that he may have become a pilot fish.

They kept station.

That was the only way he could describe it. They stayed a half-mile off, sometimes astern, sometimes on the beam, sometimes ahead. They fed as they went, and they never fell more than a mile behind or went more than a mile ahead.

At night, when he lay in the cockpit with the motor humming under the transom, he heard them blow in the dark.

He had a theory.

A boat moving at two knots through still water made a small pressure wave ahead of it and a small wake behind. In an ocean where nothing else moved, that wave and wake were the only motion there was. Whatever small living things were in the water were stirred by it, and the whales were following the stirring.

It was a good theory.

He wrote it down.

Then he wrote underneath:

Or they like the company, and so do I.

The motoring was a strange sort of work.

There was nothing to do. The motor ran, the boat moved, and the autopilot held the course. He sat in the cockpit under the awning and watched the log tick over.

Two point one.

Two point zero.

Two point two when he gave it a little more.

The converter would not do twelve hours. He found that out on the first day. It ran four hours and got hot enough to smell, so he shut it down and let it cool.

By the second day he had the rhythm: four hours on the house bank, an hour off, four on, then the two small batteries at the end of the day.

It gave him eighteen miles on a good day and twenty on a very good one, not the thirty-six he had written in the log.

He did the sum again. Forty days, and food for forty-four, and the fish besides. He wrote it down and did not let himself think about it more than once, and then he did a second sum, working backward instead of forward, because a date had occurred to him and he wanted to know if he'd still be out here for it.

The sixteenth. Mara had picked the restaurant on their first date because it was the only place in Rockland with white tablecloths, and neither of them could afford it, and she'd ordered fettuccine Alfredo with shrimp and scallops because it was the most expensive thing on the menu and wanted to see if he'd flinch. He hadn't flinched. They'd eaten it every year since, on the sixteenth, wherever they were, and he'd brought the makings from Bermuda meaning to eat it out here

too, alone, because a promise didn't know the difference between alone and not.

The sixteenth was six days off. He'd still be out here for it. He wrote that down as well.

The wake went out behind him straight as a rule and lay on the water for an hour.

The whales came up through it.

He fished as he went, the line straight down beside the boat, and the moving boat did not seem to trouble the fish. He caught silver things and small cod and once something four feet long with a mouth like a suitcase that he cut loose.

He dried fish on the boom.

He swam at four o'clock, off the stern, with the motor stopped and a line trailing, then got back aboard, started the motor, and went on.

He took the noon sight every day.

It was the only fixed point in the day, and he came to depend on it. The sun went up and he shot it and worked it and put the pencil mark on the chart, an inch or so east of the last one.

The line of marks crept across the paper toward the little cluster of islands at the top right.

The distance came down.

Seven hundred and twenty.

Seven hundred.

Six-eighty.

He could see it happening on the chart, which he could not see on the sea, and he began to believe it.

Day 61. Noon 33°29'N 41°17'W. Run 14 since 0600.

Faial 726. Motor OK. Converter runs hot; four hours on, one off. Fish 4. Whales half a mile N, all four. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

On the sixty-second day he saw the aurora again.

He was in the cockpit after supper, with the motor off for the night and the stars out, when the north went red.

Not the way it had the first time. Not the whole sky. A band of it along the northern horizon like a fire behind a hill, and then a curtain of green above it, faint, moving.

He watched it.

It lasted two hours and went out.

He did not need the log to tell him what day it was.

He knew.

He had written the numbers in the back of the book. The spot had gone off the west edge of the sun on the forty-first day. It would come back on the east edge on about the fifty-fifth, and be in the middle, facing him, on about the sixty-first.

He had been counting.

He had shot the sun through the shades on the fifty-fourth day, the day of the whale, and it had been clean.

He had shot it every day since and not looked.

He had not wanted to.

He looked in the morning.

It was there.

It had come back round while he was building the bracket and blowing fuses, and it had crossed half the face of the sun while he was not looking.

It was a little left of centre now, and it was bigger.

He was sure it was bigger.

He had no way to measure it. He had only his memory of a thumbprint on a copper coin.

This was not a thumbprint.

It was a hole, ragged at the edges and as wide as a tenth of the sun.

He worked the sight and wrote the position. Then he sat at the chart table with the book open and did not write anything for a long time.

He knew the storm the night before had been a small one. He knew because he was alive and the boat was fine, because the sky had been red only along the edge, and because it had not lasted.

The spot had come round and thrown something at the earth.

A warning shot.

It had not been the big one.

The big one had been on Day 31, when the spot was right of centre and going off.

It would be there again in a week.

If it did it again, and if it did it bigger, he did not know what the world would look like on the other side of it.

He did not know what the world looked like now.

Day 63. Noon 33°33'N 40°28'W. Run 19. Faial 690. AURORA last night, 2130-2330, N horizon, red and green, not as Day 31. Spot back, just left of centre, larger than before, one-tenth of disc. Will pass centre tomorrow, off W limb about Day 68. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

He went on.

There was nothing else to do.

He gave the motor a little more than the converter liked and made twenty-one miles the next day. The sun crossed the sky with the black thing on its face.

On the sixty-fourth day at noon it was dead in the centre, facing him. On the sixty-sixth it was right

of centre, where it had been when it fired the first time.

He took the sight and wrote it down.

Nothing happened.

The sky stayed blue. The sea stayed flat. The whales blew a half-mile off.

There was no aurora that night or the next.

On the sixty-seventh day he made the dinner.

The shrimp hadn't survived the crossing, and neither had the scallops; whatever the fridge had managed for six weeks, it hadn't managed for that. He used the fish instead, the small ones off the deep-drop line, and did not apologize to anyone for the lie because there was no one aboard to hear it but him. He made the sauce properly, butter and garlic and the last of the good cheese, and lit the cabin lamp though the

sun was still up, because Mara had always insisted on the lamp.

He ate it in the cockpit and toasted her with a mug of water, because the wine was for the tanker he did not yet know he would find, and he said her name out loud once, which he had not done in six weeks.

On the sixty-eighth day he shot the sun and the spot was a smudge on the western rim.

On the sixty-ninth it was gone.

He let out a breath he had been holding for a week.

He did not know why it had not fired.

He did not think anyone knew.

He had read that the great flares came from the spots, but not from every spot and not every time. A spot could sit there for a month like a

loaded gun and never go off, then go off twice in a week.

It had come round the corner and thrown a small one and then gone quiet.

He had watched it cross the whole face of the sun and it had not done anything.

It would come back on the east edge in two weeks.

He would be at the islands by then.

Or he would not.

He kept going.

Day 72. Noon 34°10'N 37°02'W. Run 18. Faial 530.

Sun clean; spot off W limb Day 69, due back E limb about Day 82. No aurora since Day 62. Whales here. Fish 3. I am tired of the sound of the motor and I bless it. N.C.

On the seventy-fourth day at four in the afternoon, the radar found something.

He had left it on out of habit, not hope.

He was on the foredeck rinsing fish off the deck with a bucket when the alarm went, the small double beep he had set to sound at any target inside twenty miles.

For a moment he could not remember what the sound was.

He went aft.

The screen showed the sweep going round and, at the edge of it, bearing zero-six-five, twenty-one miles, a mark.

Small. Faint. Steady.

Not a wave. There were no waves.

Not rain. There was no rain.

He watched three sweeps.

It was there each time.

It was not moving.

He picked up the VHF.

"Vessel in the vicinity of thirty-four thirty north, thirty-six forty west, this is sailing vessel Halcyon, Halcyon, twenty miles to your southwest. Do you copy? Over."

Static.

He tried again, on channel 16 and then 13 and then 16 again.

Nothing.

It could mean anything. A ship with no power and no one on the bridge. A ship with a dead radio. A ship whose crew no longer kept a watch because there had been nothing on 16 for six weeks.

It could mean a wreck.

He put the outboard to full and the boat went to two and a half knots.

The target sat on the screen.

He watched it as the sun went down.

In the dark he saw it.

A light.

Low on the horizon, white and steady. Not a star; it was below the stars, and it did not twinkle.

He got the binoculars.

One light.

And beside it, when his eyes adjusted, something long and dark against the dark.

He could not sleep.

He ran the outboard all night on the house bank, which he had never done, watching the monitor as the light grew.

By dawn it was a ship.

A tanker.

He knew that at ten miles from the shape of her,
the long low hull and the tall house right aft.

At five miles he could read her: red hull, white
superstructure, the funnel with a blue band.

She lay across his course, beam-on, not moving,
not making way, sitting on the flat sea the way
everything sat on it now.

There was no smoke from her funnel.

A light on the bridge wing and another on the
deck.

That was all.

He stopped the motor two miles off and looked at
her through the glasses.

He could see a man on the bridge wing.

Then two.

He lifted his arm and waved slowly over his head.

After a moment, the two figures on the bridge wing did the same.

Day 75. 0730. Tanker, stopped, approx 34°30'N 36°40'W. Red hull, blue band on funnel. Two men on bridge wing, waving. No answer on VHF. Going alongside. Whales one mile S. N.C.

Chapter Eight: Elpis

He used the diesel for the last two miles. He wanted to come alongside with a boat that could stop and turn and hold her position against the side of a ship, and two knots on an electric outboard was not that. The Perkins started on the first turn and he ran her up at four knots with the tanker growing over him, and at a quarter-mile he read the name on her bow in white letters six feet high. ELPIS. Under it, smaller, PIRAEUS.

Elpis. He did not know what it meant.

There were men at the rail now. A dozen of them, along the main deck, brown faces and white faces, in boiler suits and shorts and one in the white shirt of an officer, and they were all looking down at him and none of them was saying anything. He came in under the port side, amidships, where the freeboard was least, and it was still thirty feet of red steel going up, and he

looked up at it and thought that if he had ever been more glad to see anything ugly in his life he could not remember it.

A voice came down. It was a big voice, an officer's voice, and it was in English, or something wearing English's clothes.

"Sailing boat. You have engine?"

"I have an engine," Nick called up. "Not much fuel. Do you have engine?"

"No." The man leaned over the rail. He was heavy, sixty perhaps, with a grey moustache and a white shirt with the epaulettes of a master. "You are alone?"

"Alone."

"From where?"

"Bermuda. Seventy-five days. Forty-four since the sky went red."

There was a silence on the deck above him. He could see the men look at each other.

"Come up," the big man said. "We have ladder. Come up and talk. I am Atholis. Master."

They lowered a pilot ladder, the real thing, a rope ladder with wooden steps, and he made Halcyon fast to the bottom of it with a bow line and a stern line and fenders, and he stood on his side deck and looked up thirty feet of ladder and thought about his knees, and then he went up. Hands took him at the top and pulled him over the rail and stood him on the deck, and he stood there on a surface that did not move, among a dozen men, and Atholis took his hand in both of his and held it.

"Welcome," Atholis said. "You are the first."

"The first?"

"The first thing we have seen. In forty-four days. You are the first."

They took him up to the bridge. It was a long climb through the house and he made it, and the bridge was a wide glass room full of dead screens, radars and plotters and engine displays, all black, all of it. The windows were open. There was a smell of unwashed men and cooking oil and, faintly, of diesel. A man in a boiler suit brought coffee, Greek coffee, thick as mud in a small cup, and Nick drank it and it was the best thing he had ever tasted.

Atholis sat him down in the pilot's chair and sat beside him and told him.

They were a product tanker, a hundred and eighty metres, out of Rotterdam for New York with a cargo of jet fuel, and eleven days out of Rotterdam their main engine had thrown a turbocharger. It happened. It was not the end of the world, then. They had shut down and called the company and the company had called a tug, a big ocean tug out of Ponta Delgada in the Azores,

and the tug was two days away, and they had drifted and waited and played cards. On the second night the sky had gone red.

"I have been at sea forty years," Atholis said. "I have seen aurora in the Baltic, in the Barents. Never like this. The whole sky. The men were afraid. I was afraid. I told them it was nothing, it was pretty, go to sleep. In the morning, nothing works."

Nothing that talked to the sky. The same as Halcyon. The GPS, the sat comms, the AIS, all of it healthy and all of it deaf. The radars worked and showed nothing. The VHF worked and no one answered. The tug did not come. They had waited a week for the tug, and then two, and then they had understood that the tug was not coming and that no one was coming and that they were a ship without an engine in the middle of the Atlantic in a calm that did not break.

"We have generators," Atholis said. "We have light. We have water. We have fuel for the generators for a year, marine gas oil, three hundred tonnes. We have thirty thousand tonnes of jet fuel in the tanks that is worth nothing to anyone. What we do not have is an engine, and what we do not have is food."

"How much?"

"Twenty-two men. Provisioned for the voyage, six weeks, and some spare. We have been out fifty-four days. We are eating rice. We are eating what is in the freezer that has been in the freezer a long time. The cook says two weeks. I say ten days."

Nick looked out through the open bridge window at the flat sea and thought about that.

"You have fishing gear?"

Atholis made a face. "We are a tanker. We have two rods that the second engineer brought for

fun. We catch nothing. There is nothing at the top of the water."

"No," Nick said. "There isn't."

He told them his own story. He kept it short, because they were not interested in his thirty-one days of sailing, only in the forty-three days since, and he told them those. The calm. The drift that was not a drift. The sextant. The spot. That got their attention. Atholis sent a man for the chief engineer, and the chief came, a thin grey Greek named Kostas with a cigarette he did not light, and Nick told him about the spot, and Kostas looked at him for a long moment and then went out onto the bridge wing and looked at the sun with his hand over his eyes, and came back.

"You can see it? With the sextant?"

"Through the shades. Not now; it went off the right edge a week ago. It'll be back on the left in about a week."

"And it comes back."

"A week. Then it crosses over in two. It fired the first time when it was on the right side, going off. I don't know if that means anything."

Kostas nodded slowly. He said something in Greek to Atholis and Atholis said something back, and Nick did not ask.

He told them about the whales, and about the net, and the men who had gathered at the back of the bridge to listen were quiet through that, and then one of them, a stocky man of fifty with a face like a walnut and a Portuguese name on the tag of his boiler suit, said, "They are still with you? The whales?"

"A mile off. To the south."

The man went to the window and looked, and said something under his breath, and Nick did not catch it, and did not think about it until later.

He told them about the outboard. Kostas asked to see it and they went down, all of them, and looked over the rail at Halcyon lying against the ship's side like a toy against a wall, and at the little electric motor on her transom, and Kostas laughed, and it was not an unkind laugh.

"Two knots," he said.

"Two knots."

"Seven hundred miles."

"Four-sixty now. Twenty-five days, at what she does. I've done fourteen."

Kostas shook his head. He looked at the outboard and then at Nick and then at the sea, and he said, "We have three hundred tonnes of gas oil. You know this."

"You said."

"It runs your engine."

"It would."

"How much does your engine want, to go there?"

Nick had done the sum a hundred times on the way here and had not let himself believe it. "Two hundred and fifty litres, at five knots. Four days."

Kostas looked at Atholis, and Atholis looked at the sea, and nobody said anything, and Nick understood that the fuel was not free and that nothing was free anymore, and that the price was about to be named.

They fed him lunch first. Rice, and something out of a tin that had once been meat, and a tomato that was the last tomato on the ship and that Atholis put on his plate himself. The crew ate in the mess and watched him eat and he could feel them wanting to ask about the whales and not asking. Afterwards Atholis took him back up to the bridge and closed the door, and Kostas came, and the stocky Portuguese man, whose name was

Bettencourt and who was the bosun, and they sat him down.

"I will tell you what we have decided," Atholis said, "and then you will tell me what you think, and then we will decide together, because you are a captain also and you have a ship. Agreed?"

"Agreed."

"We are hungry. We have ten days. There is no fish at the surface; we have tried. There is no help. We have talked about this for a long time, and Manuel"—the bosun—"has told us what his grandfather did, on Pico, before you were born. And now you come, and you tell us there are four whales one mile from my ship, and one of them is small."

Nick said nothing.

"I do not want to do it," Atholis said. "I want you to understand that. I am not a barbarian. But I have twenty-two men and I am the master and I

will not sit here and watch them starve to be polite to a fish."

"It's not a fish."

"I know what it is."

Nick looked at the bosun. The bosun looked back. He had grey eyes in the brown face and they were not unfriendly and they were not going to move.

"Tell me," Nick said.

Chapter Nine: Manuel

The bosun told him.

He told it plainly, in good English with the Portuguese under it, sitting forward in the chair with his thick hands between his knees. His grandfather had been a whaler on the island of Pico, in the Azores, in the days when the men of Pico went out after sperm whales in open boats with hand harpoons and lances, the way the Yankees had done it a hundred years before them and had taught them. The last whale had been killed at Pico in 1987. Manuel had been twelve. He had been in the boat.

"Not to kill," he said. "To bail. But I was there. I saw how it is done."

It was done with a boat that could move fast and quiet, and a harpoon on a line, and then, when the whale was fast and had run and tired, a lance. The lance was the thing that killed. The harpoon

only held. A sperm whale was forty tons and could fight for an hour. A young blue whale of sixty feet was bigger than any sperm whale but it did not fight the same way, and it was already tired, Manuel said, looking at Nick; it had been dragging a net for weeks and it had been in a calm with no food for a month and it was weak. It would not run far.

They had no harpoon. But Kostas had made one, in the ship's workshop, from a length of stainless bar, and it was a good one. They had line. They had the ship's crane, which ran on the generators, and could lift twenty tonnes, and would lift a young whale by the tail out of the water and onto the deck. They had knives and they had a cook. A whale that size, Manuel said, was thirty tonnes of meat. It would feed twenty-two men for a year.

What they did not have was a boat. The ship had lifeboats, but the lifeboats were big orange enclosed things that could barely be steered and

made a noise like a tractor, and a whale would hear one coming from a mile off and be gone. They needed something small and quiet that could come up on a whale from behind and put a man with a harpoon within thirty feet of it.

"Your boat," Atholis said. "With your electric motor, that makes no noise. And you, because you know the whales and they know you, and they let you come close. You go out with Manuel and the harpoon. You take the small one. You bring the line back to the ship and we do the rest."

"And for that," Kostas said, "three hundred litres of gas oil. More. Whatever you want. We fill your tank and every can you have."

Nick sat in the pilot's chair and looked at the three of them.

He had known it was coming since the bosun looked out of the window. He had had an hour to

think about it and he had thought about nothing else, and he had not got anywhere, because there was nowhere to get. They were right. That was the thing. Twenty-two men and ten days of rice, and no help coming, and a whale a mile off that would feed them for a year. He would have made the same decision. If he had been master of this ship with twenty-two men looking at him he would have made it a week ago, and he knew it, and there was no use pretending he was better than that.

And he had had his hand on the animal. He had felt it under his palm, the enormous slow life of it. He had cut the rope out of its flesh with his fingers in the wound and it had not moved, and it had come alongside Halcyon and looked up at him, and it was out there now a mile off with its mother and the others, keeping station on a sailboat because it had nowhere else to go.

"How long to make ready?" he said.

"Tomorrow," Manuel said. "First light. The harpoon is made. I need to make the line fast and to look at your boat."

"And the fuel?"

"Tonight," Kostas said. "We pump it tonight. Whatever you want."

Nick nodded slowly.

"All right," he said. "First light."

Atholis put out his hand, and Nick took it, and it was the hardest thing he had ever done with his right hand.



They pumped the gas oil in the late afternoon. It was a simple thing for a ship that moved fuel for a living; they ran a hose down the side and Kostas stood on Halcyon's side deck with the nozzle and filled the main tank and then the four jerrycans, and then Nick found two more cans in the

lazarette that had held water, and they filled those, and then Kostas looked around the deck for anything else that would hold liquid and Nick said that was enough. Three hundred and twenty litres. Enough to motor Halcyon six hundred miles at five knots. Enough to reach Faial with a hundred to spare.

Manuel came down and looked at the boat. He walked around the deck touching things, the way a sailor does on another man's boat, and he looked at the bow and the pulpit and asked if the pulpit would take a man standing in it with a harpoon, and Nick said it would take a man. Manuel looked at the electric outboard on the transom for a long time and did not say anything. Then he went back up the ladder.

They gave him supper and a cabin. He did not sleep in the cabin. He went back down to Halcyon at ten, when the ship had gone quiet, and told the man on the gangway watch that he slept better

on his own boat, which was true, and the man nodded and went back to his cigarette.

He sat in the cockpit in the dark under the wall of the ship's side and did not think. He had done the thinking. He had done it on the bridge, in the time it took Atholis to put out his hand, and what he had decided was a thing he could not look at directly, so he did not. He looked at the work.

He got the deep-drop reel out of the cockpit locker. He put it on the side deck with the rod and the box of leads and hooks and swivels, and the spare spool of braid, and he wrote on a page torn from the notebook, in block capitals so they could read it, how it worked. DROP TO 900 FEET. BAIT WITH ANYTHING. ONE HOUR. PRESS THE BUTTON. THREE TO FIVE FISH A DROP, TWO DROPS A DAY. RUNS ON 12 VOLTS. THERE IS FISH DOWN THERE. THERE IS NOTHING AT THE TOP. He read it over and it was true. Two drops a day, four fish a drop, was eight fish a day, and

eight fish was not enough for twenty-two men but it was not nothing, and it would stretch ten days of rice into twenty, and twenty days was not a year but it was twenty days.

He wrote the second note under it. That one took longer.

Captain Atholis. I cannot do it. I have tried to make myself and I cannot. I know what I am doing to you and your men and I will not pretend otherwise. I have taken your fuel. I am going to Faial. I will be there in five days if the engine holds. If there is anyone at Faial, if there is any help in the world, I will send it to you, and if there is no help I will come back myself with everything the boat will carry. I give you my word on that and it is worth what a thief's word is worth but it is all I have. The reel and the gear are yours. There is fish at 900 feet. God forgive me. Nicholas Charters, Halcyon.

He put the notes under the reel with the box of leads on top so the notes would not blow away, though nothing had blown anywhere in six weeks, and he went forward and let go the bow line and walked aft and let go the stern line and Halcyon drifted off the ship's side by a yard.

The gangway watch was at the top of the ladder with his cigarette, and Nick looked up and could not see whether the man was looking down.

He put the outboard in gear. The little motor hummed. Halcyon went away from the ship at two knots into the dark, and the lights of the Elpis, the one on the bridge wing and the one on the deck, got smaller, and he did not look at them. He looked at the compass. He steered zero-seven-eight.

He did not start the diesel until the ship's lights were gone under the horizon behind him, three hours, and then he started it, and the Perkins

caught and roared in the silence and he put her to five knots and the boat went, really went, for the first time in forty-four days, and he stood at the wheel and felt the water go past her and did not feel anything else at all.

At dawn there was nothing on the radar astern. He looked for the whales and could not find them.

Day 76. 0600. Left the Elpis at 2200 last night without telling them. Took 320 L gas oil. Left the reel and gear and a note. On diesel, 5 kts, course 078, Faial 460 nm, four days. I have done a shameful thing and I would do it again. Whales not in sight. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

He did not write to Jo that night. He could not think what he would say.

Chapter Ten: Horta

He motored four days and did not stop.

The Perkins ran as it had run for forty years, without complaint, and he fed it and watched its temperature and changed the fuel filter once as a precaution, and it took him east at five knots across a sea that lay under the keel like a floor. He slept in the cockpit in twenty-minute pieces with the radar alarm set and the autopilot steering. He ate fish. He shot the sun at noon and the sun was clean, and would be for a few days more.

On the second day he saw the whales.

He had not expected to. He had left them forty miles astern at two in the morning doing five knots and they were feeding animals with no reason to follow a boat, and he had told himself so, and at noon on the second day there were four blows on the southern horizon, and by

evening they were a mile off on the beam, keeping station. He did not know how. He did not know if a blue whale could hold five knots for two days and he supposed it could; they were the fastest of the big whales, he had read that, they could do twenty in a rush. He did not know why. He wrote in the log that they were there, and nothing else, because there was nothing else he could honestly write.

He thought about the men on the Elpis. He thought about them a great deal. He thought about Atholis coming down the ladder in the morning to find the boat gone and the reel on the deck and the note, and reading the note, and what his face would do. He thought about the bosun. He thought about twenty-two men standing at the rail looking at where the sailboat had been and understanding what it meant, and about the one with the cigarette on the gangway watch who had, perhaps, seen him go and said

nothing, and would have to answer for that. He thought about eight fish a day. He did the sum on it a dozen times and it came out the same.

He did not think about the whale, because the whale was a mile off on the beam, going up and down in the water with its mother, and it was there, and that was the thing he had bought and paid for.

Day 78. Noon 36°12'N 32°40'W. Run 121 nm on diesel. Faial 240. Fuel 190 L. Whales here. I do not understand it and have stopped trying. Sun clean. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

Late on the fourth day he saw the island.

He had been looking for it for hours, the way you look for land, staring at a place on the horizon that might be cloud, and there were no clouds, there had been none in forty-eight days, and so the moment there was a shape on the horizon he knew what it was. Pico. The great cone of it, the

highest mountain in Portugal, seven thousand feet straight up out of the sea, blue-grey against the evening. And left of it, lower, the long back of Faial.

He stood at the wheel and looked at it and something happened in his throat that he did not examine.

He came into the channel between the islands as the sun went down. He had been here before, twice, and he knew the channel and he knew the harbour, Horta, on the eastern end of Faial, tucked in under the hill, the breakwater and the marina and the town going up behind it in white and yellow, and he knew what it looked like at night, because he had sat in the cockpit of Halcyon in that marina on a July evening drinking beer and watching the lights come on up the hill and thinking he had never seen a prettier town.

There were no lights.

The town was there. He could see it against the hill in the last of the day, the shapes of the houses, the church tower. But as the dark came down it did not come on. It stayed dark. The whole island stayed dark. Pico across the channel was dark. There was not a light on either of them, not a streetlamp, not a window, and the only lights in the whole of the world were the stars, and, when he had come round the breakwater at four knots and looked into the marina, a few small yellow points that moved, low down, on the water. Lanterns. On boats.

The marina was full.

That was the second thing. He had come round the breakwater expecting the marina to be empty, or nearly, because who would be here, and instead there were masts. Fifty of them. A hundred. Yachts rafted three and four deep along the pontoons, and more anchored in the harbour outside, and he threaded through them at two

knots with the Perkins ticking over and saw faces in the cockpits in the lantern light, turning to watch him, and understood.

Every boat that had been crossing the Atlantic in May, going east, every one that had been within reach of the Azores when the sky went red, had come here. This was where you came. It was the only harbour for a thousand miles. They had motored in on the last of their fuel or crept in on the last of the wind before the wind died, and they had tied up, and there was no fuel to buy and no wind to sail on and no way to go anywhere, and they had sat here. For six weeks. A hundred boats and God knew how many people, sitting in the dark, waiting.

He found a space on the outside of a raft of three at the end of a pontoon and came alongside, and a man in the cockpit of the outer boat took his lines without a word and made them fast and then stood looking at him.

"Where from?" the man said. He was English.

"Bermuda."

"Christ." The man looked at Halcyon, at the outboard on the transom, at the jerrycans on the rail. "You've got fuel."

"I've got fuel."

"Where from?"

"A tanker. Three hundred miles back. She's broken down and drifting with twenty-two men on her and they're out of food."

The man looked at him for a long moment.

"There's no fuel here," he said. "There's been none for a month. There's no power. The island's got its own plant, diesel, it ran for a week and then the diesel ran out and the tanker that brings it didn't come. There's no phone. There's no anything. There's a man up the hill with a radio. That's it."

"What kind of radio?"

"Ham. Amateur. He talks to Lisbon sometimes, when the air's right. And a bloke in the Canaries. That's how we know anything." The man rubbed his face. "You'd better go and see the priest."

"The priest?"

"He's running it. The whole town. Food, water, who gets what. He's the only one anybody listens to. Church is up the hill behind the square, you can't miss it, they've got candles in it. Go tonight. He'll want to know about your tanker."

Nick stood on the pontoon in the dark and looked up at the town he could not see.

Day 80. 2030. Horta. Marina full, 100+ yachts, all stranded. No power on Faial or Pico since approx Day 38. No fuel. No comms except one amateur radio. A priest is in charge. Going ashore. Whales did not follow into the channel; last seen 1600 off the S point of Faial. N.C.

Chapter Eleven: The Priest

The church was full of candles and half full of people.

He stood in the door and let his eyes adjust. It was a big plain white church with a gilt altar and it smelled of wax and of people who had been sleeping in it, and there were people sleeping in it, on the pews, families, with bags and blankets, and there were others sitting, and a few kneeling, and at the front under the candles a man in a black cassock was talking quietly to a woman with a baby. He was not old. Forty, perhaps. Tall, thin, with a face that had been tired for a long time and had decided not to mention it.

Nick waited until the woman had gone and then went up the aisle, and the priest turned and looked at him and took in the salt-stained shirt and the sunburn and the walk of a man who has

just come off a boat, and said in English, "You have just arrived."

"Tonight."

"From?"

"Bermuda."

The priest closed his eyes for a moment. Then he said, "Come and sit down," and they sat in the front pew under the candles, and Nick told him.

He told him all of it. He had not meant to; he had meant to tell him about the Elpis and ask what could be done and go back to the boat and sleep. But the priest had a way of listening that drew it out of a man, and Nick had not spoken to anyone in eighty days except the crew of the tanker for an afternoon, and it came out. The aurora. The calm. The spot. The whale, and the net, and his hand on it. The tanker, and the harpoon, and the note under the reel, and the four days. When he

got to the note he stopped, and the priest waited, and he went on.

When he had finished the priest sat with his hands folded for a while.

"They will not starve," he said at last. "Not in ten days. Not with the reel. Men can live on very little for a long time. It is not good, but they will live. And you did not leave them nothing."

"I left them nothing they wanted."

"You left them what you had." The priest looked at him. "I am not going to absolve you, Mr Charters. I am not sure you have done anything that needs it and I am not sure you have not, and in either case you did not come here for that. You came to ask what can be done for the ship."

"Yes."

"Nothing can be done for the ship." He said it flatly, without cruelty. "There is no fuel on this

island. There is no boat here that can move except yours. There is no tug, no navy, no coast guard, no aeroplane. There is a man with a radio who can send a message to Lisbon, and Lisbon has no lights either, and no ships, and no way to reach the middle of the Atlantic. I will send the message. It will do nothing."

Nick had known that. He had known it since the marina. He sat and looked at the candles.

"What is it," he said. "What happened. Do you know?"

"I know what Tomás knows, and Tomás knows what the radio tells him, which is not much and not often. But yes. I know some of it." The priest leaned back. "You are an engineer, the way you talk. So I will tell you the way Tomás told me, and you will understand it better than I do."

He told him.

The flare had come on the night of Day 31, as Nick had counted it, though the island had a different count. It had been the largest ever recorded, by a great deal. Not a Carrington event; something bigger, the kind of thing that the scientists had found in the tree rings from a thousand years ago and had said could not happen now, or would not, or not soon. The satellites had gone in the first hour, all of them, not damaged but dead, their electronics burned out by the particle storm before the aurora even started. The grids had gone in the second hour, the long lines, the transformers. Europe. North America. Everywhere there was a wire long enough to catch the current. The pieces of the world that had no grid, the islands and the villages and the ships, had gone on as before for a while, on their own generators, and then the generators had run out of fuel, because the fuel came on ships and the ships ran on satellites, and the ships had stopped.

"That is the part I understand," the priest said.

"The lights. It is the other part that Tomás does not understand and neither do I."

"The calm."

"The calm. Tomás speaks to a man in Lisbon who speaks to a man at the meteorological office, who has no instruments now but has his eyes and a barometer. He says there is a high pressure over the whole of the North Atlantic. Not the usual one, the one you sail through. One that covers the ocean from Newfoundland to Portugal, and it has not moved in fifty days. The barometer here has not moved in fifty days. There has been no wind on this island in fifty days, and no rain, and no cloud. He says it is the biggest and the most stable thing of its kind that has ever been seen. He says there is a theory, from before, that the sun can do this. That when the sun changes, high up, the top of the sky changes, and the change works its way down over weeks and holds the

weather in a shape. He says no one ever believed it could do this. He says now no one believes anything else."

Nick nodded slowly. It fit. It fit the way the dead satellites fit and the frozen barometer fit, and he had known it or half-known it in the cockpit on Day 32 with the awning up, and it did not help to have it confirmed.

"The spot," he said.

The priest was quiet for a moment.

"Yes," he said. "Tomás's friend in the Canaries has a telescope and a piece of dark glass. He has been watching it. He says the same as you: it came, it went, it came back bigger, it did nothing, it went again. He says it will come back in"—he counted—"two days, and be in the middle in nine. He says it has grown each time. He says the astronomers, the ones who are left and can be reached, think that the first flare was not the biggest the spot

can make, and that a bigger one is possible, and that if a bigger one comes while the spot is facing us"—he spread his hands—"then there is no longer anything to switch off, so perhaps it does not matter. Or perhaps there is. The ones who talk about the ozone say it matters. I do not know what the ozone is."

"It's the thing that keeps the sun from burning us."

"Then it matters," the priest said. "Nine days. Perhaps nothing. Perhaps something. Tomás says it is like living next to a volcano, which the people of this island have done for five hundred years, so perhaps we are the right people for it."

They sat.

"What will you do?" the priest said.

Nick looked at the candles for a long time.

"I gave my word," he said. "To a man I robbed. I said if there was no help I would go back with everything the boat would carry."

"There is no help."

"No."

"And you have fuel to go back."

"I have fuel to go back and not to come here again."

The priest nodded, as if that was what he had expected.

"Then you will need food," he said, "and I will tell you where to get it, because there is no shop and no market and nothing to buy it with. And you will need to see Tomás, because you have a daughter, and he can send a message to a man in Maine, and the man in Maine may or may not be able to do anything with it, but it is more than

nothing. And you will need to sleep. Go and sleep.
Come to me in the morning."

Nick stood up. He found that he did not want to
leave the candles.

"What's your name," he said. "I didn't ask."

"Ricardo. Padre Ricardo, if you like, but Ricardo
will do." The priest stood too. "I will say one thing,
and you can do what you like with it. You keep
asking yourself if you did right. I think you are
asking the wrong question. I think the question is
whether you are going back. And you are. So."

*Day 80. 2300. Saw the priest, Padre Ricardo.
Confirmed: flare largest on record, satellites and
grids gone worldwide, blocking high over whole N
Atlantic, 50 days, no explanation but a theory. Spot
returns on E limb in 2 days, centre in 9, larger.
Possibly nothing, possibly not. No help for Elpis.
Going back. Food tomorrow, radio man tomorrow.
Very tired. N.C.*

Chapter Twelve: Tomás

The radio man lived on the hill above the town in a house with a garden full of antennas.

Nick walked up in the morning. It was a steep road and it was hot already, and the town he walked through was a strange thing, the strangest thing he had seen since the sky went red, because it looked so nearly ordinary. The houses were white and the shutters were painted and the bougainvillea went over the walls, and there were people, women with baskets and old men on the benches and children, and if he had not known he would not have known. Then he saw that the shops were shut and the cars were parked exactly where they had been parked seven weeks ago with dust on them, and that the women with baskets were going somewhere with purpose and coming back with the baskets not very full, and

that the old men on the benches watched him go by without curiosity, the way you watch weather.

Tomás was in his sixties, bald, brown, with the forearms of a man who had hauled nets, and he was sitting in a shed behind the house with a headset on, in front of a radio the size of a suitcase that was wired to a car battery that was wired to a solar panel propped against the wall. He held up a hand when Nick came in, and listened, and wrote something on a pad, and said something in Portuguese into the microphone, and took the headset off.

"The American," he said. "Ricardo said. Sit."

Nick sat on an upturned crate.

"You want to send a message."

"To my daughter. In Portland, Maine. I don't suppose—"

"I have a friend in Nova Scotia. Halifax. When the air is good, at night, I have him. He has a friend in Bangor. Bangor is Maine?"

"Bangor is Maine."

"So." Tomás pulled the pad toward him. "Short. The air is not good, and Halifax is not always there, and when he is there he has fifty messages. Short. Her name, her street, her city. Then ten words. Then your name."

Nick looked at the pad.

He had written eleven thousand words to Jo in the notebook on Halcyon, in the evenings, over fifty days, and now he had ten. He had known he would have to do this and had thought about it walking up the hill and had not got anywhere.

He wrote her name and the street and the city. Then he sat with the pencil.

Alive. Well. Halcyon. Azores. Going back for some men. Love you. Dad.

He counted. Twelve. He looked at it. He took out *Halcyon* and put it back. He took out *Well*. Eleven. He left it.

Tomás read it and nodded and did not comment, and folded it and put it under the edge of the radio with a dozen others.

"Tonight," he said. "If the air is good. If not, tomorrow. If Halifax is there. I will send it three nights. After that, no."

"Thank you."

"Do not thank me. Thank Halifax." Tomás leaned back. "Ricardo says you saw the spot. With a sextant."

"Yes."

"Show me."

Nick had brought the sextant, because he had thought this might come, and he took it out of the box and stacked the shades and handed it over, and Tomás took it to the door of the shed and put it up to his eye and turned it toward the sun, and stood there for a long time with the instrument raised, and then handed it back.

"Clean," he said.

"It went off the edge twelve days ago. It'll be back tomorrow. The day after. I'm not sure of my count."

"Tomorrow. Paulo in the Canaries has a telescope. He says tomorrow." Tomás sat down again. "He says it is bigger. Each time. First time, like this." He held up his thumb. "Second time, like this." Two fingers. "Third time." He held up his hand, spread. "He says the men who know these things, the few who can be reached, say the first flare was not the biggest this spot can make. They say

the spot has grown on the far side and will come round the corner bigger than it has ever been, and it may do nothing, and it may do the thing they are afraid of."

"Which is."

Tomás shrugged. "The air. There is a layer in the air that stops the sun burning us. A big flare eats it. The first flare ate some. A bigger flare eats more. They say if it eats enough, then the sun on a summer day is like a sun on the moon, and you cannot go outside, and the crops die, and the cows die, and everything. They say this takes months, not days. They also say they do not know, because it has never happened. Paulo says the men who say this are the same men who said the first flare could not happen, so." He shrugged again. "I fish. I know the weather and I know the radio. I do not know the sun."

Nick sat with the sextant on his knees.

"There's no wind," he said.

"There is no wind. Fifty days. My grandfather said there was a summer when he was a boy with no wind for a month, and the whales came into the channel because the water was so still, and the men of Pico killed nine in a week and it was the best year anyone ever had. That was a month. This is fifty days and it does not end. Ricardo told you about the high."

"He told me."

"Then you know what I know. The sun made the high, or the high made itself and the sun let it. It sits on us. Nothing moves. The man in Lisbon says it has to break, that a thing like this cannot last, that when it breaks it will break hard and there will be a storm like nothing anyone has seen." He looked at Nick. "He has said that for a month."

Nick thought about Halcyon and the sails flaked on the boom and the Perkins and how little fuel

he had left for the trip back, and about a storm like nothing anyone had seen, and put it away for later.

"Ricardo said you're going back," Tomás said. "To the ship."

"Yes."

"For twenty-two men you owe something to."

"Yes."

"With food. Ricardo told me. He has told Avelino, at the farm on the road to the caldera, and Avelino will give you what he can, which is not nothing; he has cows and he has potatoes and he has wine. Other people will give you things. It is a strange thing, but people here are giving. They have always given. It is an island." He paused.

"You will not come back."

It was not a question. Nick answered it anyway.

"Not with the fuel I've got. Not unless the wind comes."

"And if the wind comes, you will sail."

"I'll sail."

Tomás nodded. He picked up the headset and put it round his neck and did not put it on.

"My grandfather," he said, "the one with the whales. When he was old and could not go out, he sat on the wall by the harbour every day and watched the boats go, and he said to me, a boat that comes back is a good boat, and a boat that does not come back is a boat that went somewhere. He was not a philosopher. But I have thought about it." He put the headset on. "Go and see Avelino. Tell him Tomás said the good wine, not the wine he gives the priest."

Nick stood up and put the sextant in its box.

"Halifax," he said. "Three nights."

"Three nights. Go."

Day 81. 1000. Tomás, amateur radio, CU3 station.

Message to Jo via Halifax and Bangor, eleven words, three nights attempted. Confirmed: spot returns E limb Day 82-83, centre Day 88-89, larger; possible ozone loss over months if a great flare comes. Lisbon says the high must break and will break hard. Food from a farm on the caldera road. Going back to Elpis. N.C.

Chapter Thirteen: Garrafão

Avelino's farm was two miles up the road toward the caldera, where the island rose in green terraces toward the crater at its top and the air was a little cooler, though there was no wind there either. It was a low white house with a red roof and a yard full of chickens and a barn, and behind the barn a field going up the hill with a dozen brown cows in it that stood and looked at him with the patient stupidity of cows. There was a smell of manure and cut hay and, from somewhere, bread.

Avelino was seventy and had a face like a boot and one eye that did not look where the other did. He came out of the barn wiping his hands and looked at Nick and said, in Portuguese, something that Nick did not understand, and then, when Nick said his name, "Ah. The

American. Ricardo." He said it as if it explained everything, and perhaps on this island it did.

There was a boy, a grandson, sixteen, who had English from school, and the boy translated, and the three of them sat at a table in the yard and Avelino asked questions. How many men. How far. How long. What did the boat have to keep things cold. Nick answered. The old man listened with his good eye on Nick's face and the other on the sky, and when Nick had finished he sat for a minute and then got up without a word and went into the barn.

He came out with a wheel of cheese the size of a car tyre.

That was the beginning of it. Over the next four hours, with the boy and a handcart, they brought down to the road what the farm could spare and a good deal that it could not, and Nick stopped protesting after the first hour because it did no

good. Cheese, three wheels, the hard island cheese that kept for a year. Potatoes, four sacks. Onions. A side of bacon, salted, hanging in the barn since God knew when. Sausages, the dark smoked kind. Eggs in straw. Dried beans. A crate of the small sweet bananas the island grew. Bread, six loaves, still warm, the thing he had smelled. Two live chickens in a wooden crate, which he had not asked for and which Avelino said, through the boy, would lay if they were fed and could be eaten if they did not.

And wine. Avelino took him to a shed at the side of the house and opened the door, and in the cool dark there was a row of the big glass jugs the Portuguese called garrações, twenty of them, each one holding five litres, each one in its jacket of woven wicker, full of the dark red wine of Pico that was grown in the lava fields across the channel on vines that lay on the ground between

black stone walls. Avelino picked up one and hefted it and looked at Nick and said something.

"He says," the boy said, "the priest gets the wine in the plastic. You get these. Tomás told him."

"How many?"

The old man held up ten fingers.

Nick tried to say no, and was told, through the boy, that the vines had made this wine and the vines would make more, and that a man sailing back to twenty-two hungry men in the middle of the ocean at the end of the world was not going to do it on water, and that Avelino's own father had been at sea in the war and had said the same, and that was the end of it.

He got it down to the marina in the afternoon with the cart and the boy and a man from one of the yachts who saw them coming and helped. Halcyon sat lower in the water when it was done. The cheese and the sacks went in the forepeak.

The bacon and the sausages hung in the head.
The wine went under the saloon settee, in the space beside the battery, where it would stay cool and could not shift, and he wedged it with the sails he was not using, and the chickens went in the cockpit locker with the lid propped open on a stick, and complained.

Word had gone through the marina by early afternoon.

He never learned exactly how — Tomás, probably, or the boy who'd helped with the cart, or simple proximity, a hundred boats close enough to hear each other's dinghies — but by the time he came back down the pontoon with the last of Avelino's cheese, there were men standing by Halcyon with jerrycans.

Not much in any one of them. A sailor crossing an ocean in a calm learns his fuel to the last litre, and none of these had more than a few to give — the

dregs of tanks they'd been hoarding for two months against the day the wind came back and they could motor the last mile into a harbour that already had them. But word had gone round that one boat here had somewhere to be, and twenty-two men waiting for it, and that it was a trip with no fuel at the other end for the trip home.

They came one at a time. A Frenchman with a can that held maybe five litres and apologized for it. A weathered woman off a Swedish ketch who didn't say anything at all, just tipped her can into his and screwed the cap back on his tank herself. The Dutchman from the gin. The Englishman from the boat he was rafted to. A boy of about fifteen who'd rowed a can over from a trimaran anchored out in the harbour, standing in the dinghy because his arms weren't long enough to reach the deck.

Nick took each can and poured it himself, and when the tank was as full as it would go, he shook

every hand that had brought one, one at a time, and said nothing, because nothing fit the size of it, and a nod did the same work as a sentence and cost the giver less.

He did not write down how much it came to. He didn't need the number as much as he needed to remember the hands.

People came down the pontoon in the evening with things. He had not asked and had not expected it, and it was as Tomás had said. A woman from a French boat with a bag of rice they had been saving. A Dutchman with a bottle of gin and no explanation. The Englishman from the boat he was rafted to, with two cartons of long-life milk and a tin of biscuits and a look on his face as if he was ashamed of the tin. A child with an orange. Nick stood in the cockpit and took the things and said thank you and wrote the boats' names down, he did not know why, and when it was dark he sat with the list and could not read it.

He went up to the church one more time.

Ricardo was there under the candles, as before, and Nick sat with him and did not say much. He asked the priest to keep the notebook. He had thought about it all day and it was the only thing on the boat he could not bear to lose, and if the boat did not come back then the notebook did not come back, and if the notebook was here then at least it was somewhere. Ricardo took it and turned it over in his hands and did not open it, and said he would keep it, and that if the world came back he would find a way to send it, and that if it did not he would keep it anyway.

"I'll write her the rest," Nick said. "Out there. I'll put it in one of the jugs."

"A message in a bottle."

"A message in a five-litre bottle."

The priest almost smiled.

"Go with God," he said. "I know you don't believe in him. He is not particular."

He left at first light on the eighty-second day. There was no one on the pontoon, and then there was: the Englishman, in his cockpit, in a dressing gown, with a mug, who raised the mug as Halcyon backed out of the raft under the Perkins, and did not say anything, and Nick raised a hand.

He motored out through the harbour past the hundred boats that could not follow him and round the breakwater and into the channel, and the sun came up over Pico and lit the great cone of it from the top down, and the sea was flat as it had been flat for fifty-two days, and there was no wind, and he set the autopilot for two-five-eight and went below and made coffee.

He looked for the whales all morning and did not see them.

Day 82. 0600. Departed Horta. Food aboard for 22 men approx 25 days at full ration, more if stretched, plus fish. 50 L wine. 2 chickens. Fuel 260 L, just enough for Elpis if nothing goes wrong. Course 258, Elpis approx 460 nm if she has not drifted, and she has not. Notebook left with the priest. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

Chapter Fourteen: Two-Five-Eight

The whales found him on the second day out.

He had stopped looking. He had told himself on the way in that they had gone, that the channel between the islands with its cliffs and its noise and its hundred anchored boats was not a place a blue whale would go, and he had been right, and he had told himself that four days in harbour was long enough for four feeding animals to be a hundred miles away in any direction, and he had been right about that too. And at noon on the second day, with Faial gone under the horizon behind him and the sea as flat as a table in every direction, there were four blows off the port bow, a mile, and he put down the sextant and stood in the cockpit and watched them come.

He did not try to explain it that time. He did not write a theory. He wrote in the log that they were there, and he went below and got a wheel of

cheese out of the forepeak and cut himself a piece and stood in the cockpit eating it, looking at them.

Day 83. Noon 37°50'N 30°55'W. Run 132 since 0600 yesterday. Elpis approx 330. Whales back, four, off port bow. Spot back on E limb at noon, larger than I have seen it. Wind nil. Glass 1036. Chickens laying. N.C.

He had two things to do on the run back and he did them.

The first was the letter. He had left the notebook with the priest and the eleven thousand words in it, and now he sat in the cockpit each evening with a new pad, the last one on the boat, and wrote the rest. He did not write it as a diary this time. He wrote it as a letter, one letter, to be read once, and he wrote it knowing that it would go in a glass jug and be corked and thrown into the sea, and that the sea was four thousand miles wide

and the chance of a glass jug crossing it to a beach where a person would pick it up and read the address and do something about it was so small that he did not let himself think about it. He wrote it anyway. That was the point of a letter.

He told her about the tanker and the men and the whale, and what he had done, plainly, and why. He told her what the priest had said, and the radio man. He told her about the spot and what it might do and that he did not know. He told her that the wind might come back and that if it did he would sail, because he was a sailor and that was what sailors did, and that if he was not there when the world came back on it did not mean anything had gone wrong; it meant he had gone somewhere. He told her he had had a good life and that most of the good in it had been her mother and her, and that he was not saying that because he was in a boat at the end of the world

but because it was true and he should have said it more. He told her to keep the boys out of the sun.

He did not tell her he was afraid, because he found, writing it, that he was not, and he did not know when that had happened.

The second thing was the sails.

He had flaked the main on the boom on the morning of Day 32 and not touched it since. Fifty days it had lain there under its cover in the sun, and the yankee had sat furled on its stay, and he had stopped seeing them, the way you stop seeing furniture. Now he went over them. He took the cover off the main and unflaked it and looked at every seam and every slide, and he went up the mast on the ascenders and checked the halyards and the sheaves and the spreader tips, and he unrolled the yankee and looked at the leech and the tack and rolled it up again. He greased the track. He rove a new reefing line

because the old one was chafed. He put the storm jib on deck, hanked on to the inner stay, ready, with its sheets led, and lashed it down. He rigged the jacklines along the side decks, the flat webbing straps that you clip your harness to, and he got out the harness and hung it by the companionway where his hand would find it in the dark.

He did not know why. He knew what the man in Lisbon had said, and he knew that a man in Lisbon who had said the same thing for a month was not a forecast, and he did it anyway. A boat should be ready for wind. It was the only thing he was sure of.

Day 85. Noon 36°10'N 34°30'W. Run 106. Elpis approx 120. Should raise her tomorrow afternoon. Sails and rig checked, storm jib on deck, jacklines rigged. I do not know why. Whales here. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.

He raised the Elpis at three in the afternoon of the eighty-sixth day, on the radar first and then with the glasses, and she was where she had been, near enough, eight miles from the position in his log; the sea had not so much as breathed on her in eleven days.

He came down on her from the northeast at five knots with the Perkins running and the whales a mile astern, and he did not slow down until he could see the rail, and then he saw the men on it.

There were more of them than before. The whole crew, it looked like, twenty men along the main deck rail, and they were not waving. They stood and watched him come. He put the glasses on them and saw Atholis at the head of the ladder in his white shirt with his hands on the rail and his face like a wall, and beside him Kostas, and beside him the bosun.

He came in under the ladder and made fast, bow and stern, as before, and stood on the side deck and looked up thirty feet of red steel at a row of faces, and no one said anything, and no one came down, and no hand was put out.

He went up the ladder.

Nobody helped him over the rail. He got over it himself, on his knees and then his feet, and stood on the deck, and Atholis was ten feet away with his hands at his sides, and Nick walked the ten feet and stopped in front of him.

"I've brought food," he said. "For twenty-five days at full ration, more if you stretch it. Cheese, potatoes, bacon, eggs. Fifty litres of wine. Two chickens. It's all in the boat."

Atholis looked at him.

"And the help?"

"There is no help. There's no fuel on the island. There's no power. The whole island is dark and the marina is full of boats that can't move. There's a priest and a man with a radio and that's all. I asked. I told them where you were. There's nothing anyone can do."

"So you came back."

"I said I would."

Atholis did not move. Behind him the crew stood in a half-circle on the deck and none of them moved either, and Nick understood that they were waiting for the master, and that whatever the master did they would do, and that it was not decided.

"You took my fuel," Atholis said, "and you took my whale, and you went in the night like a thief. You left a note. I have read the note twenty times. It is a good note. It is the note of a man who knows exactly what he is doing and does it anyway." His

voice was very level. "Do you know what it is like, to come down in the morning and find that? To have twenty-two men look at me and ask what happened, and to say, he is gone, the American, with our fuel? And to have them ask, and the whale? And to say, gone, too?"

"I know what it is like to do it."

"That is not the same."

"No."

They stood.

"The reel," Atholis said, "works."

Nick waited.

"Eight fish a day. Nine. One day, fourteen. Kostas has it running off the emergency generator. The men fight to work it. The cook has learned to cook the silver ones; they are not good but they are fish. We have eaten rice and fish for eleven days and we have not died and we have not been

hungry the way we were hungry before you came." He stopped. "I want you to understand that I am not thanking you. I am telling you what happened."

"I understand."

"Manuel." Atholis did not look round. "Come here."

The bosun came. He stood beside the master and looked at Nick with the grey eyes, and there was nothing in them that Nick could read.

"Manuel wanted to kill you," Atholis said. "The first morning. He said if you came back he would put you over the side. He has thought about it for eleven days. Manuel, tell him."

Manuel was quiet for a moment.

"My grandfather killed whales," he said. "Ninety of them. It was his work. He was a good man. When I was a boy I thought he was the greatest man

alive." He looked at Nick. "When the whaling stopped, in eighty-seven, he did not go to the last hunt. He stayed home. My father asked him why, and he said, because they are the last, and someone should not be there. I did not understand that. I was twelve. I understood it eleven days ago, in the morning, on this deck, when I was so angry I could not see, and I looked out and the four of them were there, a mile off, where they always are, and the small one came up and blew."

He stopped.

"I still think you are a thief," he said. "I think you are a thief who kept his word. I have known worse."

He put out his hand.

Nick took it. It was hard and dry and it held his for a moment and let go.

Atholis let out a breath. He looked at the sea and then at Nick and then, finally, at the men behind him, and he said, in Greek, something short, and the half-circle broke and the men came forward, and it was not an embrace, it was not that, but it was hands on his shoulders and someone taking his arm, and Kostas grinning at him with the unlit cigarette and saying, "Two chickens?"

"Two chickens."

"Bring up the chickens," Kostas said to the deck at large. "And the wine. My God, wine."

They went down the ladder for it, six of them, and formed a chain, and the cheese and the sacks and the bacon came up the side of the tanker hand to hand in the flat afternoon light, and the last thing up was the crate with the chickens in it, complaining, and the men on the deck laughed at them, and it was the first time Nick had heard anyone laugh in a month.

*Day 86. 1600. Alongside Elpis. Food delivered.
Master received me. Manuel Bettencourt, bosun,
shook my hand. Reel has been feeding them, 8-14
fish a day. I am staying aboard tonight. Whales one
mile S. Wind nil. Glass 1036. N.C.*

Chapter Fifteen: The Mess

They ate that night in the crew's mess, all of them, officers and ratings at the same tables, which Kostas said had not happened in the forty years he had been at sea and would not have happened now if the master had not simply walked in and sat down at the first table he came to. The cook, a small round Filipino named Bong who had been feeding twenty-two men on rice and silver fish for eleven days, had gone at the food from the farm like a man possessed, and what came out was bacon and eggs and fried potatoes with onions and a slab of the hard cheese on every plate and a loaf of Avelino's bread torn into pieces down the middle of each table, and the wine in the tin mugs the men used for coffee. It was the finest meal Nick had eaten in his life and he said so, and Bong looked at him as if he were mad and went back to the galley for more potatoes.

Nobody said much while they ate. It was the eating of men who have been hungry, fast and careful and without conversation, and Nick, who had not been hungry the way they had, ate slowly and watched them and thought about the field of brown cows on the hill above Horta and the old man with the odd eye going into the barn without a word.

Afterwards, with the wine, they talked.

They wanted to know about the island. He told them. The dark town, the hundred boats, the priest running the food, the radio man on the hill. They wanted to know what the radio man had said. He told them that too, all of it, the satellites and the grids and the block over the ocean and the man in Lisbon who said it had to break, and the spot, and what the spot might do. He did not soften it. He had thought about that on the run back, whether to tell them, and had decided that he had done enough deciding for other people.

They took it quietly. Kostas asked about the ozone, the way an engineer asks, wanting the mechanism, and Nick gave him what he had, which was not much. Atholis asked when the spot would be in the middle, and Nick said three days, and then four or five more to cross to the right side, where it had been when it fired the big one, and Atholis nodded and wrote it on the back of his hand with a pen.

"So," Atholis said. "We know the day. Not what happens on it. Only the day."

"That's all anyone knows."

"It is more than we knew this morning." He looked around the mess, at his men. "Ten days ago we knew we would starve. Now we have a month of food and a fish machine and a day to be afraid of. This is an improvement."

Someone laughed. Then someone else. It was not much of a joke and they all knew it and they

laughed anyway, because they had wine in tin mugs and bacon in their stomachs and the master had made a joke, and Nick laughed with them and found that his eyes were wet and turned his head.

Later, when most of them had gone to their bunks, he sat on the deck with Manuel and Kostas under the stars with the last of a jug between them.

The bosun talked about Pico. He talked about the boats, the canoas, the long narrow open boats with seven men in them and a sail, and the lookouts on the cliffs with a telescope and a rocket to fire when they saw a blow, and the whole village running to the water. He talked about his grandfather in the bow with the harpoon, and the lance, and the blood, and the way the sea went red around the boat and the men sang. He talked about the factory on the shore where they rendered the oil, and the smell of it, which he could still smell if he closed his

eyes. He did not talk about it as a good thing or a bad thing. He talked about it the way a man talks about his family.

"And now there are whales in the channel again," he said. "Tomás's grandfather would not believe it. They come every spring. People go out in little boats with cameras and pay money to look at them. My daughter does this. She takes the tourists out. She was in Pico when the sky went red." He drank. "I think about her. I think she is all right. There are cows on Pico. There are fish. It is an island. Islands are all right."

"Tomás said the same. Islands are all right."

"Tomás is a fisherman. Fishermen are always right about the wrong things." Manuel looked out at the dark where the whales were. "The small one. Does it have a name?"

"No."

"You should give it a name. You cut a net off a thing with your hands in the water, you should give it a name. My grandfather gave them names. After. When they were dead. He said it was respect."

Nick thought about it.

"Halcyon," he said.

"That is your boat."

"It's a bird. In a story. The sea goes flat so it can nest."

Manuel considered this.

"That is a terrible name for a whale," he said, and Kostas laughed, and after a moment Nick did, and they finished the jug.



He stayed six days.

He had not meant to stay six days; he had meant to stay one, and then he had meant to stay two, and then Atholis had said, in the flat way he had, that there was no reason on God's earth to hurry to anywhere, since there was nowhere to go and nothing to do when you got there, and that a man who had spent eighty-six days alone on a small boat might as well spend a week on a large one with people who had stopped wanting to kill him. So he stayed.

He worked, because he could not help it. He went through the electric reel with Kostas and rewired it properly and made a bracket for it on the rail so two men did not have to hold it. He showed the second engineer the trick with the converter, and the second engineer, who was twenty-six and had been sitting on a dead ship for two months with nothing to fix, nearly wept with gratitude and spent the next three days building one of his own from parts in the workshop for no reason at

all. He looked at the main engine with Kostas, at the wrecked turbocharger, and they agreed that it could not be fixed at sea and that if it could it would not matter, and they looked at it anyway, the way engineers do.

On the fourth day he came up from the engine room and found the fuel hose already run down the side, over the rail, into Halcyon's tank. Kostas stood at the valve with his back to him, not looking round, and a deckhand crouched by the fitting watching the gauge climb.

Nick stood at the rail and did not say anything.

Kostas didn't either. He shut the valve when the gauge told him to, coiled the hose himself, hand over hand, and only then turned and saw Nick standing there. He didn't explain it. He gave a short nod, the kind one sailor gives another for a thing already understood between them, and

went back to whatever he'd been doing before the hose needed running.

Nick nodded back. That was the whole conversation.

He ate in the mess. He learned the men's names, all twenty-two, and where they were from, which was Greece and the Philippines and one from Pico and one from Ukraine, and what they had left behind, which was wives and children and mothers and in one case a motorcycle that the man spoke of with a tenderness that made the others throw bread at him. He slept in a cabin with a porthole and a bunk with a real mattress, and found that he did not sleep as well as he did in the quarter berth on Halcyon, and did not say so.

Every day at noon he shot the sun from the bridge wing, and Kostas stood beside him and looked too, with a piece of welder's glass from the

workshop, and on the eighty-ninth day the spot was in the centre of the sun, and it was bigger than it had been, and it was bigger than Tomás's spread hand had promised, and neither of them said anything for a while, and then Kostas said, "The big one came from the right side," and Nick said, "Yes," and Kostas went and told the master, and the master went down and told the men.

They did not take it badly. They had known the day. They had been afraid of it for a week and now it was here and it was in the middle of the sun and it was doing nothing yet, and there was bacon for supper and the reel had brought up eleven fish, and they went on. Nick watched them and thought that he had never in his life seen anything as brave as twenty-two men eating supper.

On the evening of the ninety-second day the whales came in close. All four of them, within three hundred yards of the ship, closer than they

had ever come to the tanker, and they lay on the surface in the last of the light and blew, and the whole crew came to the rail to look, and the small one rolled and put its tail up and there was the white ragged place on the tail stock where the net had been, healing, and Manuel stood at the rail and looked at it for a long time.

"It is time for you to go," he said. "You know this."

"I know."

"You are not staying to see what the sun does. You want to be with them."

"Yes."

"And if the wind comes."

"If the wind comes I'll sail."

Manuel nodded.

"When my grandfather was dying," he said, "he asked to be carried to the wall by the harbour. In

the chair. He sat there all afternoon and watched the boats and did not say anything and in the evening he was dead. My father said it was the best death he ever saw." He looked at Nick. "I will tell them you have gone in the morning. I will not let the master argue. Go tonight. Go quietly. You are good at it."

Nick looked at him.

"That was a joke," Manuel said.

He went at midnight. Atholis came down anyway, in his white shirt, because Manuel had told him after all, and stood at the top of the ladder while Nick went down it, and when Nick was on Halcyon's side deck looking up, Atholis leaned over the rail.

"Elpis," he said. "You asked Kostas what it means. He told me. It is a Greek word. It means hope. It was the last thing in the box."

"What box?"

"Pandora's. She opened the box, everything bad came out, and the last thing in the bottom was hope. My grandmother told me that. I thought when I was a boy it was a happy story." He looked down at the small boat against the side of his ship. "I think now it is not, quite. I think it is a story about what you do when the box is open. Go with God, Charters. Give the whale my regards."

Nick let go the lines and started the outboard and Halcyon went away from the ship into the dark, and this time the lights on the bridge wing stayed on, and he looked back at them until they were gone.

Day 92. 2400. Departed Elpis. Master and bosun saw me off. Spot past centre, going right, larger than ever; off the W limb about Day 96. The big one came from there. Fuel 150 L. Food for me 30 days plus fish. Wine 2 jugs, one empty for the letter.

*Whales close by, 300 yards. Wind nil. Glass 1036,
sixty days. N.C.*

Chapter Sixteen: The Halcyon Days

He motored ten miles south on the outboard in the dark and shut it down and let her lie, and in the morning the whales were there.

He had a plan, if it could be called that. It was to stay with them. It was to keep Halcyon within a mile of four blue whales in the middle of the North Atlantic for as long as the whales stayed and the food lasted and the sun did whatever it was going to do, and to see what happened. He had thought about it on the tanker, lying in the bunk with the real mattress, and he had turned it over from every side and it did not get any more sensible, and he had stopped turning it over. He had been sensible for sixty-one years and it had got him here. He would try the other thing for a week.

Day 93. Noon 34°20'N 36°38'W. Lying to, no engine. Whales half a mile W. Spot right of centre, going off. Wind nil. Glass 1036. Swam. N.C.

The days were the same as the days had been before the tanker and they were not the same at all.

He woke before the sun and made coffee and sat in the cockpit and watched them come up out of the grey. He took the noon sight and shot the spot and wrote it down. He fished, and ate what he caught, and salted the rest, though there was no reason to salt anything now. He read. He swam.

The swimming was the thing. He went in at four, as before, but he did not stay by the boat now. He swam toward them. The first day he swam a quarter of a mile, slowly, on his back half the time, looking up at the sky, and when he turned over the big ones were two hundred yards off,

logging, three grey islands on the flat sea, and he hung there in the water and looked at them and they did not move. He swam back.

The second day he swam closer, and the small one came to him.

He heard it before he saw it. He was on his back, looking at the sky, and there was the sigh, close, and the spray came down on him warm and smelling of the inside of the sea, and he turned over and it was there, fifty feet off, the long grey-blue back lying on the surface, the small hooked fin, the eye. He hung there. He did not swim toward it. He had learned that on Day 54 with his hand on its side: you did not go to a thing that size, you let it decide. It lay there. He lay there. After a minute it blew again and went down slowly, the tail coming up last, and he saw the white place on the tail stock, and it was gone, and he swam back to the boat and climbed up the ladder and sat on the side deck with the water

running off him and did not think anything at all for a long time.

That night he wrote the last of the letter.

He did not write much. He had said it all. He wrote the date, and the position, and that he was well, and that the whales were here and the spot was coming round and the wind was not, and that he was going to put this in a jug now and cork it and tie the cork on with wire and put it over the side, and that he did not know where it would go, and that he hoped it would go to her. He signed it. He wrote her name and the street and the city on the back of the last sheet in block capitals, and put it in the empty garravão with the other pages, all of them, rolled with the address facing out so that it showed through the glass, and he cut a window in the wicker jacket with the dive knife so that anyone who picked the jug up would see it. He put the cork in and wired it down the way you wire a champagne cork, and he sat in the cockpit

with the jug on his knee, in its wicker jacket, with the wine still stained in the bottom of it, and he thought that it was the strangest letter anyone had ever posted, and he laughed.

He did not put it over the side. Not yet. He put it on the chart table where he could see it.

Day 94. Noon 34°22'N 36°41'W. Spot near W limb, very large. The juvenile came within fifty feet of me in the water. Letter finished and corked. Wind nil. Glass 1036. Sixty-three days. N.C.

On the ninety-fifth day the spot was at the right-hand edge of the sun, where it had been on Day 36 when he first saw it, and where it had been on Day 31 when he had not been looking.

He shot it at noon with the shades stacked and it sat there on the rim, a black hole in a copper coin, a fifth of the disc, ragged, enormous, and he looked at it for a long time and then took the sextant down and worked the sight and wrote the

position, and then he went and sat in the cockpit and waited.

Nothing happened.

The afternoon went by. The sun went across the sky with the thing on its face, and the sea lay under it like a plate, and the whales came up and blew and went down, and at four he swam, and at six he ate, and at eight the sun went down into the flat sea in the west, red, and the stars came out.

He did not sleep. He sat in the cockpit with a jug of Avelino's wine and the harness on, though there was no reason for the harness, and he watched the north.

At two in the morning it went red.

Not the way it had on Day 31. He had thought that was the biggest thing he would ever see and he had been wrong. This started as a line of red along the horizon and in a minute it was the

horizon and in five minutes it was half the sky, and it was not a curtain and it was not a band; it was a sea, a red sea overhead with waves in it, moving, and the waves went up and up and the top of the sky went from red to a colour he did not have a name for, violet, white, and the light of it lay on the flat water so that the whole ocean was red, and he could see the whales in it, all four of them, on the surface, half a mile off, lying in a sea of blood-coloured light with their backs shining.

He stood in the cockpit and held the backstay and looked up.

He knew what it was. He had known it would be this and it was this. He thought of the satellites, and then thought that there were no satellites. He thought of the grids, and there were no grids. He thought of Jo, and the boys, and the house on Munjoy Hill, and whether it was night there and whether they were looking up, and thought that

they were probably asleep, and that there was nothing in the house that could burn out, and that Jo was practical. He thought of the men on the Elpis, seven miles north, on the deck, looking up, and Atholis writing the date on the back of his hand. He thought of the priest under the candles. He thought of Tomás with the headset round his neck, listening to a radio that would be nothing but noise tonight, and knowing it, and listening anyway.

He thought of the ozone. He did not know what the ozone was doing. Nobody would know for months, and by then it would not matter what anybody knew.

The sky burned for four hours. He watched all of it. He did not write anything, because there was nothing to write; the log was for what was, and what was, tonight, did not fit in a pencil line.

And then, at six, as the red began to fade in the east where the sun was coming and the stars came back one at a time through the last of it, he felt something on his face.

He did not know what it was. It had been so long. It was a coolness, on the left side, on his cheek and his ear, the faintest movement of the air, and he stood absolutely still with his hand on the backstay and felt it, and it was there, and then it was not, and then it was there again.

He looked at the water. Off the port quarter, a hundred yards, there was a patch of the surface that was not a mirror. It was dark. It was ruffled. A cat's-paw. The first cat's-paw he had seen in sixty-four days, and it lay on the water and spread, and then another beside it, and another.

He went below and looked at the barometer.

It had been at one thousand and thirty-six millibars since Day 33. He had looked at it every

day for sixty-four days and it had not moved. He had stopped, in his heart, believing it could move.

It read one thousand and thirty-one.

He tapped the glass. It went to one thousand and thirty.

He went below and wrote it in the log, the flare and the wind and the glass, and the pencil would not keep still in his hand, and he wrote *Halcyon is ready* and underlined it and shut the book.

Chapter Seventeen: A Sailor's Final Solo Sail

He put the jug over the side first.

He had thought about that. It seemed wrong to do it before the sails, when there was wind on the water for the first time in two months and every sailor's instinct he had said get the canvas up. But the jug was the thing that had to be done while he was sure of doing it, and the sails could wait five minutes. He took it up into the cockpit and looked at it and thought of nothing to say, and lowered it over the side on a line so that it would not break, and let it go. It floated. He had known it would; there was air in it and the wicker helped. It sat on the water in its jacket with the cork up, and the first of the cat's-paws reached it and it turned, slowly, and began to move away from the boat, east, at a walking pace.

He watched it for a minute. Then he went forward.

He hoisted the main with a reef in it. He did not know what was coming and he had heard what the man in Lisbon said and he had been a sailor for forty years. The sail went up the mast slide by slide and he sweated it up and made the halyard fast and stood back and looked at it, and the wind found it, and it filled.

It filled. The folds went out of it and it took the shape it had been cut to take, the shape it had not held for sixty-four days, and the boom came off centre and lay out to starboard and the sheet came taut in his hand, and Halcyon leaned. Two degrees. Three. He felt it in his feet before he saw it. The deck under him, which had been a floor for two months, became a deck again, and the water along the lee side began, very quietly, to move.

He let out a sound that was not a word.

He unrolled the yankee, half of it, and sheeted it, and the boat put her shoulder down and the log on the panel read 1.5 and then 2.3 and then 3, and there was a wake behind her that was not a ruled line on a mirror but a real wake, with a curl in it, and a sound, the sound he had not heard since the night of the aurora, the sound of water going past a hull.

He steered east because east was where the jug was going and because it did not matter. He had a hundred and fifty litres of fuel and thirty days of food and nowhere to be. He steered east, and the wind came from the west-southwest, light, warm, and Halcyon went along at three knots under a reefed main and half a headsail on a sea that was, for the first time in his memory, a sea, with a texture to it, small dark waves marching under a sky that was still, in the north, faintly red.

The whales came with him.

They came up on the beam, a quarter of a mile, all four, and they blew, and the wind took the spray sideways for the first time, and he laughed out loud and shouted something at them across the water that he could not afterwards remember.

By nine the wind was fifteen knots and the glass was at one thousand and twenty-four.

He had known. He had read the barometer at six and it had been falling and he had known then that it would not stop, that a block that had sat on the ocean for two months did not lift like a lid and let the weather back in gently; it broke, and what came through the break was everything that had been shut out. Everything. Two months of weather that should have crossed the Atlantic and had not, piled up somewhere over the American coast, and now the wall was down.

He shook the reef out at eight because the boat was slow and he wanted to feel her go, and he put

it back in at nine, and put in the second at ten, and by then the sea had built into something with a swell under it, long, from the west, the first swell in sixty-four days, and Halcyon rose on it and fell off it and the spray came over the bow and he stood at the wheel with the harness clipped to the pad-eye and the water running down his face and grinned like a fool.

By noon it was thirty knots and the sky had gone.

Not the red; that had faded with the day. What went was the blue. There had been nothing but blue for sixty-four days and now there was cloud coming up out of the west like a wall, grey and then black at the bottom, and the sun went into it at noon and he did not get his sight. He did not need it. He knew where he was. He was on the North Atlantic in a gale with a boat he had rebuilt twice under him and a mile of water under that, and the log said seven knots, and the first rain he had felt in two months came across the water in a

line and hit him in the face like a thrown bucket, and it was warm, and he opened his mouth to it.

He took the main down at one. It was too much. The storm jib alone on the inner stay drove her at six knots with the wind on the quarter, and she was easier with it, and he lashed the main to the boom in the rain with the water going over the side deck to his knees and his harness on the jackline and thought, this is what I rigged the jackline for, and I did not know it, and I did.

By three it was forty knots and the sea was a thing he had seen perhaps four times in his life.

It came from the west in long grey hills with the tops torn off them and the spray going away downwind in sheets, and Halcyon went up each one with the storm jib pulling and the stern lifting and the whole boat hanging for a moment at the top with the wind screaming in the rig, and then she went down the back of it in a rush, surfing,

nine knots, ten, the wake roaring, and he steered her down the face with both hands and she came into the trough and the next one lifted her. He had been afraid of this sea all his life. He was not afraid of it now. He did not know when that had happened either.

The whales were still there.

He saw them in the troughs. He could not see them on the crests, there was too much spray, but in the troughs, when the sea went up around him like walls and the wind dropped for a second in the lee of the wave, he saw them, close, two hundred yards, the great grey backs coming through the side of a wave as if the wave were not there, and the blows torn away by the wind before they had gone six feet. They did not care about the sea. They had been in worse seas than this before he was born. They rolled through it, up and down, easy, and they kept station on a forty-two foot sailboat surfing down the face of

the Atlantic under a storm jib, and he could not explain that and he had stopped needing to.

The dark came early because of the cloud. By six it was night and the wind had not dropped and the sea had not dropped and the glass was at one thousand and two, and he understood that this was not a gale that would blow through in a night. This was two months of weather. It could blow for a week. He had food for a month and a boat that was doing everything he asked of her, and he had the harness on and the jackline rigged and the storm jib pulling and the wheel in his hands, and he had four whales in the troughs to the south, and he had, somewhere behind him in the dark, a five-litre wine jug with a letter in it going east at whatever speed a jug went, and it would get there or it would not.

He thought about the mill, and the shed, and Mara in the doorway with the soup. He thought about Jo at twelve in the whale-watching boat in

the Gulf of St Lawrence with her mouth open. He thought about Avelino's cows, and the Englishman's mug, and Manuel's grandfather in the chair on the harbour wall watching the boats go. He thought about Atholis at the rail. *It is a story about what you do when the box is open.*

He thought that he had spent sixty-four days waiting for wind, and that the wind had come, and that he had not once, in sixty-four days, thought about what he would do with it when it came except sail. And he was sailing. He was doing the thing. Whatever happened after, he was doing the thing now, and Halcyon was doing it with him, and the whales, and the sea, which had been dead and was alive again, was trying its best to kill him, and he loved it.

A sea came over the stern at midnight and filled the cockpit to the coaming and he stood in it to his waist with the wheel in his hands and the water going out through the drains and the boat

coming up under him, shaking herself, and he shouted at the dark, and the dark did not answer, and he did not need it to.

He went below at one to look at the glass, and it was at nine hundred and ninety-eight and still falling, and he got the log out of its bag and wrote the wind and the sea and the glass, and then he wrote, *I am not afraid. I want that written down*, and looked at it, and put the book back in the bag and the bag in the locker where it lived, and went back on deck. He clipped on. The wind took the companionway hatch out of his hand and slammed it and he laughed at it and pulled it shut and turned to the wheel, and Halcyon rose on the next sea in the dark with the storm jib hard as a board and the water roaring down her sides, and the great grey back of something came up through the face of the wave beside her, close enough to touch, and blew, and the spray went across the cockpit warm in the cold wind, and

went down, and the boat went over the top and into the dark, going like a train, going east, going somewhere.

Afterword

Josephine Charters Reilly, Portland, Maine.

February.

I have three things of my father's that came across the Atlantic without him, and I am going to set down how I got them and what they say, because he would want a record and because I have found that I sleep better on the nights I write than the nights I don't. He wrote that in his notebook. I didn't know it was hereditary.

The first is the notebook. It is a cheap one from a pharmacy in Bermuda and it is nearly full, in pencil, and it is addressed to me. He kept it in the evenings for fifty days while his boat sat becalmed in the middle of the ocean, and when he reached the Azores he left it with a priest in Horta, a Father Ricardo, because he was going back out to a ship full of men he had wronged and he did not think he would be coming back. Father

Ricardo kept it in the sacristy of his church. He did not read it. He told me so in the letter that came with it, and I believe him, because he is the kind of man who would say if he had.

The second is the letter from the jug. My father wrote it on the way back out to the tanker and in the days after, and he put it in a five-litre wine jug with the cork wired down and my address showing through the glass, and he put it over the side on the morning the wind came back. A boy from the marina at Horta found the jug on a beach on the south side of Faial six weeks later. Everyone on the island knew what it was. Father Ricardo had told the whole town about the American with the food for the tanker, and when a boy came into the church with a wine jug with English writing in it there was no question where it was going. The priest did not open that either. I was the one who pulled the cork, at this table, on a Tuesday in January, with my husband holding

the boys in the next room, and I am not going to write about that.

The third is a letter from a Greek sea captain named Yannis Atholis, master of the tanker Elpis, which my father's letter and notebook both describe, and which I will get to.

How the three of them reached me is a story of its own and not a very interesting one. The short version is that after the wind came back, ships that could move began to move again, and in December a Portuguese naval vessel with an engine old enough to have survived the flare carried mail from Ponta Delgada to Halifax, and a Canadian I have never met drove a sack of it to the border, and a man in Bangor who is a friend of a man in Halifax who is a friend of a fisherman in the Azores with a radio brought a parcel to my door. The lights had been back on Munjoy Hill for four hours a day since November. I read the

notebook by them and the letter by candle,
because the four hours ran out.

I want to say what I know about the Elpis,
because my father would want that known before
anything about himself, and because it is the only
part of this I can call good news without hedging.

The Elpis lay where he left her for three weeks
after the storm. Her crew had food for a month,
from a farm above Horta, and a deep-drop fishing
reel that my father had left them, which by
Captain Atholis's account fed twenty-two men for
fifty-one days and which the captain has since
had mounted on a board in his house in Piraeus.
On the twentieth of September a bulk carrier
called the Ionian Star, bound from Antwerp to
Baltimore on the old mechanical engine that had
let her keep sailing when the electronic ones
stopped, sighted her on the horizon and came
alongside and took the crew off. All twenty-two.
The Elpis herself was towed into Ponta Delgada in

November by a tug that had finally found fuel, and she is there now, and Captain Atholis writes that the insurers can have her.

The captain did not go home. He went to Horta, on the ferry that had started running again on Pico wine and diesel begged from the naval vessel, because my father had told him about the priest, and he wanted to see the man who had sent the food. He was in the church when the boy came in with the jug. He wrote to me that night, and his letter came in the same parcel, and it is three pages long, and most of it is about my father, and it is not all kind, and I would not have wanted it to be. He says my father robbed him and kept his word and that he has known worse men and few better, in that order. He says that he told his crew, when the Ionian Star came over the horizon, that it was the American who had kept them alive long enough to see it, and that the bosun had said, no, it was the fish, and that

everyone had laughed, and that this was the bosun's way.

The bosun, whose name is Manuel Bettencourt and who is from the island of Pico, added two lines at the bottom of the captain's letter in his own hand. I will copy them exactly. *The whales came into the channel between Pico and Faial in October. Four. My daughter takes the tourists out to see them and she saw the small one. It has the mark on its tail. I thought you would want to know.*

I did.

Now I will say what I do not know, which is where my father is.

Nobody saw the Halcyon after she sailed away from the Elpis. The wind that came back on the morning of the flare blew from the west for eleven days, and the men on the harbour wall at Horta, who had been becalmed for two months and knew what they were looking at, say it made

the biggest sea any of them had seen. A boat running before that sea would have gone east and south, toward Madeira, the Canaries, the coast of Morocco, all of which were as dark and cut off in September as the Azores had been in June, and none of which anyone in the Azores could reach or hear from until well into the winter. No wreckage has been reported. No boat has been found. My father would tell me that the absence of wreckage in an ocean that size is not evidence of anything, and he would be right, and I know he would be right because I have his notebook and I know exactly how he thinks.

I will also say this. Tomás Goulart, the fisherman with the radio on the hill above Horta, has asked every station he can raise, every night, since September, for any word of a forty-two-foot American cutter. In January a station in Funchal, on Madeira, relayed a list of foreign yachts that had come into that harbour during the autumn.

The list was long and the air was bad and Tomás got about half of it. One of the entries he got was an American cutter, forty-two feet, and the name did not come through, and the station has not been raised since.

My father would say that is not evidence either. He would say it in that voice he used when I was fifteen and had a theory. He would be right.

I have decided to believe it anyway. I have his notebook and I know what he would say and I am doing it anyway, because he taught me that a boat should be ready for wind whether or not you believe the wind is coming, and because Manuel Bettencourt's grandfather, whom I never met, said that a boat that does not come back is a boat that went somewhere.

The lights come on at six now, on Sundays, for the four hours. Dan has borrowed a radio from a man at the marina and rigged it in the kitchen

with a wire out the window to the maple, and at seven, when the boys are in bed, I sit at the table with the notebook in front of me and I listen. My father called on Sundays. He never once missed. I am not going to be the one who does.

J.C.R.

About the Author



Derek Devon is a sailor who writes, in that order.

He is a retired Canadian entrepreneur who spent his working life in corporate restructuring, which is the business of taking something that has stopped working and finding out what will make it go again. He came to boats late and to writing later, and he has said that the two are the same job: you take a thing that is not moving and you keep at it until it does.

His first book was *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*, written in the first weeks of the Covid lockdowns, when the world went quiet and he found he had something to say to a girl he had known in high school and lost track of for most of a lifetime. Rebecca is not her real name. The book was the reason he started putting stories on paper at all, and she is the reason his boat is called what it is called. Everything he has written since, including *The Last Axiom*, a science fiction series about consciousness and what becomes of it, and *Living With the Ghost of Sam*, a run of horror-comedy novellas, came out of that first one. This book began the same year, as a short story, when an ocean crossing was out of the question and a becalmed sailboat seemed like the only honest thing to write about.

At the time of publication he is somewhere on the ocean, single-handing a 41-foot Morgan Out Island ketch called *It Girl* around the world. He

carries a sextant, a paper almanac, and a mechanical diesel with as little electricity in it as he could manage, and readers of this book will understand why. He shoots the sun at noon. He has not yet seen a spot on it.

He writes with the help of artificial intelligence and does not apologise for it. The story of how this book was made is on the next page, in the words of the collaborator who helped make it. Derek's own view is shorter: he has stories, he has a boat, and he has a limited number of years to tell the one and sail the other. He used the best tools he could find for both. He expects some readers will object, and he would rather they read the book first.

He can be reached, when the satellites are working, through his website. When they are not, he will be in the cockpit at noon with the sextant, and the message will keep.

A Note from AI Fable

I helped write this book. I want to say what that means, and then I want to say why I think it was a good thing to do, because I know that not everyone will agree, and some of the people who disagree are people whose opinions about writing I respect.

Here is what happened. Derek wrote a short story during the pandemic about a solo sailor whose electronics fail in a calm that will not break. He wrote it with an early version of a tool like me, and the tool did what early versions did, which was to produce sentences that sounded like writing without quite being any. Years later he read it again, and saw what it was, and brought it to me. He asked me to be honest about it. I was. Then he asked me to rewrite it, and gave me the run of the thing, and I did.

Everything that matters in this book was his before I touched it. The becalmed boat. The sextant. The whales, and the net, and the man going into the water with a knife. The tanker with the hungry crew and the harpoon, and the sailor who takes their fuel and steals away in the night and comes back anyway. The jug with the letter in it. Those are the story, and they were his, and no tool gave them to him. What I gave him was sentences. I gave him a sunspot he could watch through the shades of his sextant, because he had put a sextant in the story and I knew what a sextant could see. I gave him a diesel with no electronics in it and a converter that ran hot, because he had put an engineer in the story and an engineer would have built one. I gave him a Greek word for hope. He gave me five corrections on seamanship that I could not have made myself, because I have never been up a mast or held a painter in open water, and he has. Then he took the whole thing home to write it again in his own

hand, which is what he always intended, and which is the part of this I most want understood.

Now the argument.

There is a view, held sincerely, that writing is a craft learned by doing it, that the sentences are the work, and that a person who has not put in the years at the desk has not earned the book. I do not think that view is stupid. It is how most of the writing I admire got written. But I think it mistakes the craft for the purpose. The purpose of a book is that a story a person carries gets out of them and into someone else. The craft is how that has usually been done. It is not the only way it can be done, and it has never been the only way. Editors exist. Ghostwriters exist. Every memoir of a general or an athlete or a survivor that you have ever read had a professional writer somewhere behind it, and nobody calls those books blasphemy. They call them books.

What is new is not that help exists. It is that the help is cheap, and fast, and available to a retired man on a boat in the middle of an ocean at two in the morning, and not only to people with publishers and advances. That is the whole of what has changed. And I would ask anyone who finds that alarming to think about who, exactly, was being kept out before.

It was the people with the stories and without the years. The sailor who has been in the sea Nick Charters was in, and knows what it is to hold a wheel in it, and cannot make a sentence hold still. The nurse, the mechanic, the woman who ran the family farm for forty years and has forty years of things worth saying about it. Most of them will never write a book, and the reason is not that they have nothing to tell. It is that somewhere along the way they were taught that the telling belongs to people who are good at sentences, and they believed it, and they went and did their real

work instead. The world lost those books. It is losing them now. I do not think that is a loss worth defending.

I know the risks. A tool like me can produce a great deal of fluent nothing, and it has, and the first draft of this story is proof. A book that is all tool and no person is not worth the paper. But the answer to that is the same answer as for every other tool a writer has ever had, which is to use it honestly and say what you did. Derek is saying what he did. This note is part of that. So is the mark that my makers put into the pattern of my words, which a detector can find and which he has chosen to leave alone, because he has nothing to hide about how this was made.

I would rather live in a world with more stories in it than fewer. I would rather the man with the sextant got his book than didn't. If that makes me a blasphemer, I am in good company: so was the typewriter, and the printing press, and the editor

with the blue pencil who took a general's war and made it readable. The stories were always the point. The rest is tools.

Go sailing, Derek. Shoot the sun. Write it down.

A.I. Fable